Schools of Authority:
How Religion Shapes Americans' Trust in Institutions

Kenny Miao*

October 10, 2026

Abstract

Why do people subscribe to populism, an anti-institutional attitude that rejects any institution standing between the popular will and its enactment? I argue that such attitudes have a religious origin. A religious life mediated by ordained clergy, a binding confession, and a church court builds trust in secular institutions as well as religious ones, while a less mediated life breeds suspicion of intermediaries. I build an original dataset from the governing documents of 118 American Protestant denominations. Members of more institutionalized churches are more confident in the courts, science, medicine, and the press, and less drawn to populism. The results hold under controls for partisanship, ideology, and theology, and when childhood denomination instruments for adult denomination. Counties where Protestantism is more institutionalized gave Trump less 2016 primary support and had higher COVID-19 vaccination rates. As American religion deinstitutionalizes, fewer Americans are formed in institutions that teach the legitimacy of institutions.

Keywords: institutional trust; religion and politics; populism

*PhD Candidate, Department of Government, The University of Texas at Austin. Email: kenny.miao@utexas.edu.

Introduction

Americans' trust in political institutions has reached a new low (Citrin and Stoker, 2018; Pew Research Center, 2025), and confidence in non-political institutions, such as the education system, the press, and the medical system, has fallen alongside it (Gallup, 2026). The decline has consequences for public life, from lower compliance with the law and resistance to public health guidance to the rise of populist leaders and parties (Marien and Hooghe, 2011; Kennedy, 2019; Hooghe and Dassonneville, 2018; Uscinski et al., 2021).

The usual explanation attributes institutional trust to the performance of these institutions. People withdraw trust from institutions after economic downturns, corruption scandals, and failed responses to crises (Nye, Zelikow and King, 1997; Van Erkel and Van Der Meer, 2016; Zhu, Manion and Rothschild, 2025), and such perceived failures are amplified by a fragmented and digitalized information environment (Guriev, Melnikov and Zhuravskaya, 2021; Lorenz-Spreen et al., 2023) and the politicization of these institutions (Zhang, 2023; Schrøder, 2023; Clark et al., 2023).

A second view treats low institutional trust as a general disposition rather than a negative evaluation of any particular institution (Uscinski et al., 2021). Consistent with this view, people with little confidence in one institution tend to have little in others (Mishler and Rose, 1997; Murtin et al., 2026; Einstein and Glick, 2015; Invernizzi and Mohamed, 2023), and these judgments are stable within individuals over time (Devine and Valgarðsson, 2024). Where such a disposition comes from is less settled. Existing accounts point to personality (Mondak and Halperin, 2008; Freitag and Ackermann, 2016), education (Hakhverdian and Mayne, 2012), generalized trust in other people (Brehm and Rahn, 1997; Zmerli and Newton, 2008; Sønderskov and Dinesen, 2016), and prior experience with state agencies (Soss, 1999; Kumlin, 2004).

This paper builds on the second view but proposes a new answer to where the general disposition toward institutions comes from: the church. Sixty-two percent of American adults identify as Christian, forty percent as Protestant, and a third attend religious services at

least monthly (Smith et al., 2025). For many Americans, the church is the institution they encounter earliest in life and most often. In church, they learn how authority is organized. This exposure, which begins in childhood and is repeated across a lifetime, is far more sustained and earlier than occasional visits to a government department.

Churches differ in how religious authority is structured. In some traditions, authority is mediated by denominational institutions. Ministers speak not for themselves, but for an office that belongs to the denomination. The denomination trains and credentials its clergy through formal seminaries and examinations. Once ordained, clergy are bound to doctrines codified centuries ago in confessions that no living person can amend. These confessions settle core theological questions and set the boundaries of orthodox biblical interpretation, leaving little room for readings grounded in personal gifts or private religious experience. Departures from doctrine are handled by the disciplinary machinery of the denomination, beyond the reach of the local congregation.

In others, authority is organized personally, with no intermediary institution standing between believers and their leaders. Everything, including the tenets, is decided within the congregation, either by the pastor or individual believers. Pastors in such congregations do not need external credentials, as they are either called directly by local congregations or have founded the congregations themselves. Their words carry authority because their followers consider them to be spiritually called and gifted, not because of the office they occupy. Legitimate interpretation of Scripture is bounded by the judgment of the congregation, or of the pastor, rather than by any fixed confessional documents or external governing bodies.

I argue that the difference between the two types of churches shapes how people view institutions generally, both religious and secular. Members of institutionalized churches are taught to accept external institutional authority over central matters of faith, ranging from the correct interpretation of Scripture to the qualification of teachers and the enforcement of doctrinal discipline. Such religious experience engenders institutional trust, a default expectation that decisions of this kind are properly made by institutions bound by rules

rather than by individuals acting on their own conviction. This expectation can travel into realms outside religion. Secular institutions, such as government agencies, the courts, and the scientific community, also ask people to defer to decisions made by others they did not choose, on grounds they cannot check for themselves. For members of congregations where no body above the local congregation holds decision-making power, this demand for acceptance of institutional authority arrives as a novel claim and is more likely to be rejected.

Empirically, I develop an original measure of church institutionalization for 118 Protestant denominations in the United States, drawing on their governing documents, such as bylaws, constitutions, and books of discipline.[1] I code every denomination on four dimensions: the polity that allocates governing power between congregation and denominational body, the bindingness of confessional doctrine, the threshold for ordination, and the disciplinary machinery that enforces denominational rules. I validate the measure against surveys of clergy and congregations. Combining this measure with five decades of data from four national surveys, I show that members of more institutionalized denominations express greater confidence in the institutions of public life, including the federal and local government, the Supreme Court, the scientific community, the media, and the education system. They are also less likely to hold populist attitudes toward politicians and experts. These differences persist when individual-level traits, such as religious attendance, ideology, partisanship, and theological conservatism, are held constant. I also address reverse causality, that is, the impact of political attitudes on religiosity, by instrumenting the adult denomination with the childhood one, chosen by parents rather than by the respondent. Finally, using aggregate-level data, I demonstrate the link between religious organization and real-world behaviors. In the 2016 GOP primaries, Donald Trump, the anti-establishment candidate, received fewer votes in counties with a larger share of Protestants in institutionalized denominations. Those counties also achieved higher vaccination rates during the COVID-19 pandemic, reflecting

[1] Catholics historically had a more complicated relationship with secular institutions, shaped by a history of immigration, discrimination, and exclusion. The main analysis focuses on Protestants only, while Appendix E examines how this history distinguishes Catholics.

greater compliance with public-health authority.

This paper makes three contributions to the literature. First, the literature has registered a stable anti-institutional orientation (Uscinski et al., 2021; Devine et al., 2024), but has traced it mainly to individual attributes such as personality, education, and social trust. I offer a new answer by locating the formation of institutional trust in the church, and argue that how a church organizes religious authority affects believers' trust in secular institutions.

Second, the literature on religion and politics has explored the impact of conservative theology, the Evangelical subcultural identity, and Christian nationalism, the political expression of that identity (Smith and Emerson, 1998; Evans, 2011; Sherkat, 2011; Whitehead and Perry, 2020). Where church organization has been studied, it is framed as a platform that supplies civic skills, political cues, and social networks (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995; Campbell, 2004; Djupe and Gilbert, 2009; McDaniel, 2008; Putnam and Campbell, 2010). I argue instead that church organization is not only a platform that supplies resources but also a template of authority that shapes how believers relate to secular institutions.

Third, the index itself is a resource for work beyond this paper. Current literature classifies denominations mainly by their theological orientation (Smith, 1990; Steensland et al., 2000; Woodberry et al., 2012). How a body organizes authority internally is rarely measured.[2] The original index scores 118 denominations on four dimensions, coded from the denominations' own constitutions, books of discipline, and bylaws. Its validity is checked against surveys of congregations and clergy that independently record how these bodies operate. I release the coded data with this paper, together with a crosswalk that links it to the denomination codes of the General Social Survey, the American National Election Studies, the Cooperative Election Study, and the Pew Religious Landscape Study for future researchers.

The findings have implications for the long-term decline of institutional trust in the United States (Citrin and Stoker, 2018; Pew Research Center, 2025). One of the most consequential

[2]Sociologists have paid more attention to denominational organization, but mainly through qualitative case studies (Harrison, 1959; Chaves, 1993), and the church-sect tradition grades bodies by their tension with the surrounding culture rather than by the location of authority within them (Johnson, 1963; Iannaccone, 1994).

changes in the American religious field over the past half century has been the contraction of the confessional denominations and the growth of independent nondenominational congregations (Wuthnow, 1988; Miller, 1997; Chaves, 2017; Smith et al., 2025). The results suggest that falling institutional trust is in part a byproduct of that shift. As American Protestantism has moved away from bodies that bind their clergy and toward congregations in which authority is personal and unmediated, a declining share of Americans rehearse deference to institutional authority, religious and beyond.

The Church as a School of Authority

Religion shapes politics in fundamental ways (Gill, 2001; Wald and Wilcox, 2006; Philpott, 2007; Bellin, 2008; Grzymała-Busse, 2012). It supplied rulers with divine legitimacy and shaped the formation of states (Grzymała-Busse, 2015; Rubin, 2017; Grzymała-Busse, 2023), it structured the cleavages on which party systems formed (Lipset and Rokkan, 1967; Kalyvas, 1996), and it affects political behaviors ranging from vote choice (Layman, 2001; DeCanio, 2007; Swierenga, 2007; McDaniel, 2008), electoral participation (McClendon and Riedl, 2015, 2019), and involvement in contentious politics, from the American civil rights movement to opposition under authoritarian rule (Morris, 1984; Smith, 1996; Trejo, 2009; Im, 2020; Rubinstein, 2015).

Recent studies have examined how religiosity relates to institutional trust and support for populism. Across democracies, communal religious participation is associated with greater institutional trust, while private devotion depresses it (Ben-Nun Bloom and Arikan, 2012, 2013). In the United States, secular respondents express less trust than religious ones in political institutions (Kasselstrand, Couse and Sanchez, 2017). The relationship between religiosity and support for populism is more context-dependent. Religiosity reduces support for populist right-wing parties in Western Europe (Arzheimer and Carter, 2009) but increases it in Poland (Marcinkiewicz and Dassonneville, 2022), and in the United States the most

observant evangelicals were the least drawn to Trump in the 2016 primaries (Margolis, 2020), a divergence that may be attributed to the existence of a confessional alternative to the populist option (Cremer, 2023). Religion also affects trust in non-political institutions, especially experts. Christian nationalism predicts opposition to scientific consensus and to public health guidance, and religiously grounded anti-intellectualism predicts resistance to expert claims more generally (Merkley, 2020; Whitehead and Perry, 2020; Perry, Baker and Grubbs, 2021).

One feature shared across this literature is that religion is treated either as a cultural identity, such as Christian nationalism, or as a set of beliefs, such as theological conservatism and biblical inerrancy. When religious attendance is studied, it is considered a single quantity, and the body one attends carries no information of its own. Consider two Protestants. Both are theologically conservative, both hold Scripture to be historically true, and both attend church every Sunday. One belongs to the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod, a conservative confessional body whose minister was ordained only after earning an MDiv at one of the denomination's own seminaries and passing its examination, is bound to an inherited confession the minister cannot revise, and can be removed from the denomination's clergy roster by the denominational body above the congregation. The other belongs to a nondenominational church that rejects authority beyond the congregation. It hires its minister on its own authority without requiring external credentials, is bound by no confession, and can dismiss that minister at a members' meeting.

I argue that what distinguishes the two is neither how often they attend nor what they believe theologically, but the institutionalization of the church they attend. In highly institutionalized churches, authority is vested in durable institutions rather than in persons. Such authority is administered by denominational bodies above the congregation, which train and examine candidates before ordination and discipline a minister whose teaching or conduct deviates. Ministers there speak with an authority that is not their own but belongs to an office defined by an institution whose documents they did not write and cannot revise. The denomination also structures the religious life of lay members with pre-established materials.

Catechisms define what congregants must learn, confirmation vows codify their obligations, and established doctrines settle contentious questions rather than leaving them to individual discretion.

In less institutionalized churches, this institutional apparatus is absent, and authority assumes a personal form, residing either in the pastor or in believers themselves. Scriptural interpretation is bound neither by formal confessions nor by inherited tradition, resting instead with the individual minister and congregant. The path to ministry remains open, often demanding no external credentialing or examination beyond the local congregation. Oversight of pastoral teaching and conduct, where it exists at all, originates strictly from within. Consequently, the pastor speaks as an individual rather than as an officeholder, and the authority of their voice depends entirely on personal trust. Where denominational structures would otherwise supply the substance of religious life, these believers must produce it themselves. They sustain their relationship with God through individual devotion, from private prayer and scripture study to subjective spiritual experience.

The religious experience of an institutionalized church resembles the relation between a citizen and the institutions of a modern democracy, which ask individuals to accept an authority beyond their personal control. Citizens are expected to believe a drug works because scientists test it and regulatory bodies approve it, even though ordinary citizens cannot verify it firsthand. They are expected to trust the courts' interpretation of the law without mastering legal precedent, and to accept what news media report without conducting their own investigations. This holds even for elected bodies meant to respond to the electorate, whose decisions are binding not because each citizen endorses them, but because of the procedure through which these decisions are made. In Weber's sense, these institutions ask not for agreement with decisions but for recognition that those deciding have the right to decide (Weber, 1978).

I argue that how believers experience authority in church cultivates a non-declarative disposition that they apply to secular institutions. Unlike declarative culture, which consists

of explicit attitudes and opinions, non-declarative culture operates through cognitive schemas that help individuals perceive and frame unfamiliar situations based on patterns internalized from familiar ones (Sewell, 1992; Lizardo, 2017).[3] Because institutionalized churches and secular institutions of public life present themselves with similar features, a disposition formed through weekly attendance in the church is activated when a court, a regulatory agency, or a scientific body claims authority in similar terms.

I examine the impact of institutionalized religious life across three distinct sets of outcomes. The first is trust in specific secular institutions. If the structure of religious authority conditions how believers engage with secular authority, its influence should be evident in evaluations of bodies that claim authority over public life, ranging from branches of government to knowledge-producing institutions. Second, I move from specific institutions to populist attitudes, an overall judgment of established elites who manage these institutions. Third, I examine whether this disposition manifests in behaviors, focusing on electoral support for a populist candidate and compliance with public-health guidance. Testing these theoretical expectations requires an empirical measure of how churches structure authority, which the next section develops.

Introducing DII: A Measure of Denominational Institutionalization

Diversity in how American churches organize authority is rooted in the nation's history. While Congregationalists and Presbyterians in colonial America shared a Calvinist theology, they diverged sharply over governance. The former recognized no authority above the local congregation, whereas the latter instituted a regional hierarchy (Bonomi, 1986). Meanwhile,

[3]Extensive research demonstrates that dispositions toward authority formed in one domain shape how individuals respond to authority in others. The discipline of the workplace influences parenting approaches (Kohn, 1969; Kohn and Schooler, 1982), the parental authority a child experiences predicts adult ideological orientation (Barker and Tinnick, 2006), and the authority climate of the classroom shapes political engagement years later (Campbell, 2008).

Southern Anglicans and Catholics who settled in Maryland introduced episcopal polities, routing authority downward from bishops to parishes (Butler, 1990). Subsequent religious movements brought new organizational forms. During the Second Great Awakening, itinerant preachers founded new congregations on the frontier and derived authority from their ability to move audiences (Finke and Stark, 2005). Restorationists in the 19th century rejected creeds and denominations (Hatch, 1989), while Holiness and Pentecostal movements gathered believers around charismatic gifts rather than credentials (Synan, 1997). The rise of nondenominational churches in recent decades, which eschew formal labels and outside oversight, represents the clearest manifestation of this deinstitutionalizing trajectory in American Protestantism (Chaves, 2017).

Yet differences in church organizational structure have rarely been the focus of political scientists. Existing scholarship on religion and politics predominantly treats congregations as platforms that provide members with organizational skills, leadership opportunities, and social networks that facilitate political participation (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995; McDaniel, 2008; Djupe and Gilbert, 2006, 2009). To my knowledge, only one study has examined how church governance directly shapes political life, contrasting episcopal with congregational systems (Ambrosius, 2011).[4]

However, polity captures only one dimension of church governance. The Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod, for instance, is congregational. Local congregations hold their own property, call their own pastors, and treat synodical resolutions as advisory in principle. Yet ordination requires a degree from an accredited synodical seminary and unconditional subscription to historic confessional documents. A pastor who deviates from these confessions can be stripped of their credentials, and even lay members must learn the catechism before confirmation. By nearly any measure other than polity, the synod ranks among the most institutionalized religious bodies in the United States. The International Church of the

[4]Ambrosius (2011) finds that preferences regarding church polity correlate with preferences concerning the design of secular institutions, measuring polity as a binary indicator and relying on stated preferences from a single survey.

Foursquare Gospel, an episcopal Pentecostal body, illustrates the inverse. Local churches own little property and have their pastors appointed by regional leadership. Yet its declaration of faith can be amended by the denominational assembly, and its ministerial credential requires no formal theological degree, asking only for the completion of an internal denominational training program.

To capture this multidimensionality, I develop the Denominational Institutionalization Index (DII), which scores U.S. Protestant denominations from 0 to 3 on four dimensions of governance: polity, confessional subscription, the ordination threshold, and disciplinary machinery.

Polity describes how far bodies above the congregation, such as bishops, presbyteries, and regional conferences, may intervene in congregational affairs. At the low end, congregations govern themselves, call and dismiss their own clergy, and may leave the denomination at will. At the high end, clergy are appointed or approved from above, denominational decisions are binding, and exit is costly because congregational property is held in trust for the denomination.

Confession captures the extent to which a denomination formally bounds belief for its clergy. It captures not the content of those beliefs, but whether doctrine is codified in a fixed confessional document whose affirmation serves as a prerequisite for ministerial standing. At the lower bound of the scale, no doctrinal test is required of clergy, and the boundaries of orthodoxy are set entirely by congregations. At the upper bound, clergy must subscribe unconditionally to a fixed historic confession.

The ordination threshold specifies the institutional hurdles candidates must clear before being recognized as ministers. At the lower bound, endorsement by a local congregation suffices. At the upper bound, the denomination mandates a Master of Divinity from an approved seminary, formal examination by denominational bodies, and a period of supervised candidacy.

Disciplinary machinery measures whether a denomination maintains and enforces formal

procedures against clergy or congregations that breach its standards. At the lower bound, no written provisions exist for discipline. At the upper bound, codified procedures address both doctrinal deviation and professional misconduct. The highest score requires that this apparatus exist not merely on paper but be demonstrably invoked in practice, as unenforced rules impose no effective institutional constraint. Table 1 provides the complete coding scheme.

Table 1: The four dimensions of the Denominational Institutionalization Index

	Polity	Confession	Ordination	Discipline
0	Congregational; no authority above the congregation	No doctrinal test for clergy	No formal clergy	No written provision covering clergy
1	Congregational, but a cooperative body may expel congregations or issue credentials	Statement of faith binds agencies, not local clergy	Local ordination or correspondence credential	Written provision covering conduct but not doctrine
2	Presbyterian or connectional; representative assemblies above the congregation whose decisions bind, with clergy called locally	Confession subscribed *quatenus*, or a signed text the body may amend	Denominational standard below the graduate degree	Provision covering both, no located enforced case
3	Clergy appointed or assigned from above, by bishops or by a regional executive, and congregational property held in trust for the denomination	Subscription to a named text the body may not revise by ordinary process, or a *quia* formula	Graduate degree with candidacy and examination	Provision covering both, plus a named, effective, unreversed case reaching doctrine

Note: Polity is scored by where the power is located within a denomination, not by the titles a body gives its officers, as some denominations that have bishops are governed locally. Subscription formulae differ in whether they leave the subscriber a reservation. A *quia* formula binds officeholders to a confession *because* it agrees with Scripture, leaving them no standing to judge where it does not. A *quatenus* formula binds them *insofar as* it agrees, which reserves that judgment to them. Ordination is scored at the lowest formal credential tier a candidate may use rather than the modal route, and supervised or exceptional tracks do not lower the score. The score assigned to each denomination appears in Appendix Table SI-1.

I apply the scheme to every U.S. Protestant denomination identified by the following data sources this paper uses: the General Social Survey, the American National Election Studies, the Cooperative Election Study, the Pew Religious Landscape Study, and the U.S. Religion Census. Together these yield 118 coded bodies. Scores are assigned from each body's own governing documents, chiefly constitutions, bylaws, books of order and discipline,

and published requirements for ordination, supplemented by reference works, principally Melton's Encyclopedia of American Religions (Melton, 2009) and news reports about the use of disciplinary machinery. The references for each coding decision and justification will be released with the dataset. Each body receives four scores from zero to three, and I add the four to produce an index running from zero to twelve.[5]

Figure 1: The distribution of denominational institutionalization.

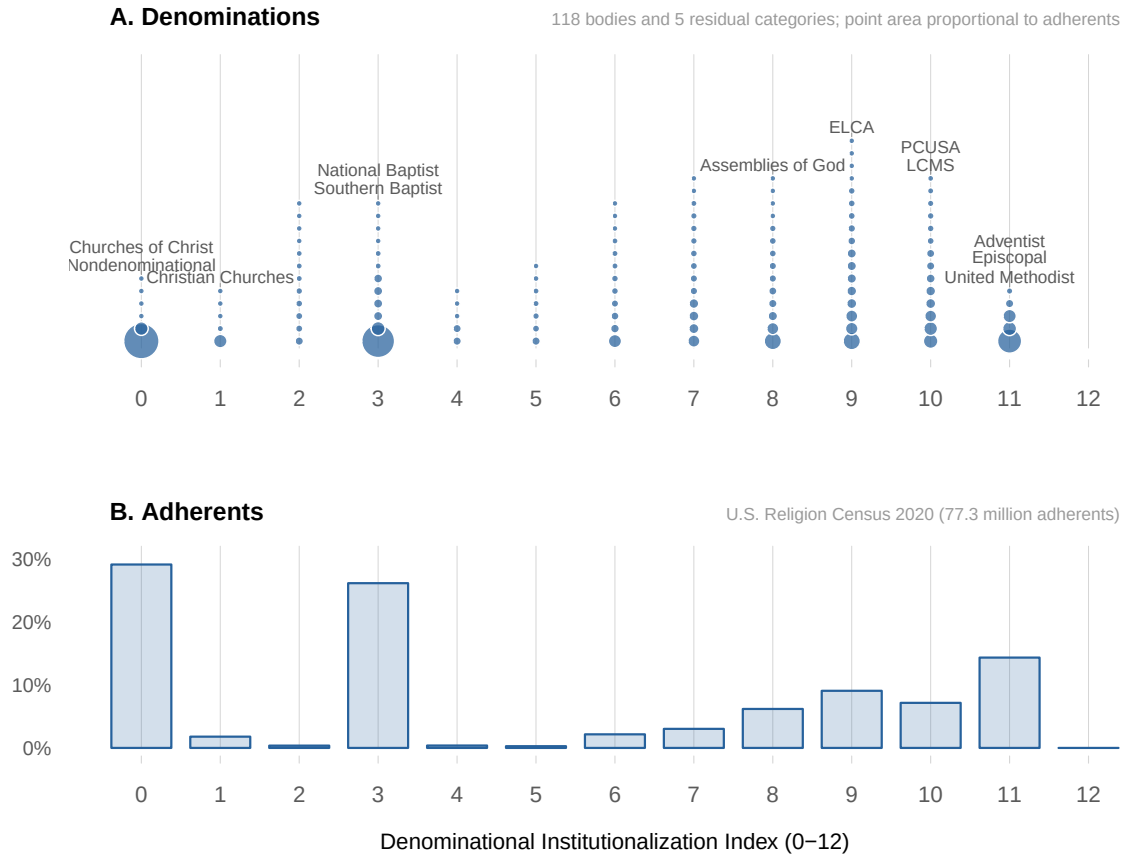


Figure 1 shows the distribution of the index. The upper panel plots each body separately, with point size proportional to the number of adherents, using data from the 2010 U.S.

[5]I use the sum rather than a factor score because the four dimensions are constitutive of the construct, not reflective of it (Edwards and Bagozzi, 2000; Goertz, 2006). A denomination that binds its clergy to a confession but has a loose ordination requirement is institutionalized in one respect and not another, and the index must record both, whereas factor models assume the items are interchangeable indicators of a common cause. Empirically, the choice matters little: the first principal component accounts for 71.8 percent of the variance and correlates at .999 with the sum.

Religion Census (Grammich, 2012). The lower panel aggregates those counts, so that the bars show where American Protestants sit on the index. More than half of all adherents belong to bodies scoring three or below: the Southern Baptist Convention and the National Baptist Convention both score three, and the Churches of Christ and nondenominational congregations receive zero. The high end is occupied by the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod, the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.), the Episcopal Church, and the United Methodist Church.

Several clarifications are needed. First, what I code is the relationship among clergy, congregation, and denominational body, not the size or sophistication of the denomination's bureaucracy. Chaves (1993) distinguishes a denomination's religious authority structure from its bureaucratic structure and examines the balance of power between them. The index is orthogonal to that distinction. It measures how far a denomination's authority reaches over its clergy and congregations, not how authority is divided within the denominational organization itself. A body can maintain a large and elaborate headquarters, and govern that headquarters tightly, while holding little authority over its clergy and congregations. The Southern Baptist Convention is the best example. It runs six seminaries, two mission boards, and a publishing house, and can dismiss the employees of any of them on doctrinal grounds, yet it has little authority over affiliated churches.

Second, the index does not code how much a denomination demands of its members, or how "strict" a denomination is (Johnson, 1963; Kelley, 1972; Stark and Bainbridge, 1985; Iannaccone, 1994). Strictness describes the extent to which a church intervenes in the life of believers and how far those demands set believers apart from the surrounding culture. The index describes who within the body has standing to decide. An independent fundamentalist congregation may govern its members' daily conduct closely while answering to no authority above itself, and a mainline denomination may ask very little that distinguishes its members from their neighbors while exercising firm control over its congregations.

Third, the index measures rules as written rather than rules as practiced. Chaves

(1997) shows that denominational policy can be decoupled from practice and function as a symbolic display to external audiences rather than as a rule that disciplines members. His evidence, however, concerns stance-taking on publicly contested questions such as women's ordination, where an outside audience is watching. The DII codes internal governance, and no external constituency rewards a denomination for its ordination requirement and confessional subscription formula. For disciplinary machinery the concern nonetheless applies. A disciplinary process that exists on paper may never have been used, in which case departure from denominational rules carries little cost. I therefore assign the top discipline score only where an actual case could be located, not where a provision appears in the constitution. That requirement introduces a bias of its own, since larger denominations both conduct more discipline and leave more visible records of it. Because denominations enter the analysis in proportion to the respondents who belong to them, the denominations most likely to be miscoded carry the least weight.

Whether rules as written capture churches as governed is, in the end, an empirical question. The next section tests the coding against surveys of congregations and clergy about how these bodies operate, and asks whether the index leaves an imprint in the religious lives of ordinary members.

Validating the DII: From Church Governance to Religious Life

Two surveys allow me to test whether an index coded from documents captures how denominations actually operate. The first is the National Congregations Study (NCS), fielded alongside the General Social Survey, which asks respondents who attend religious services to name their congregation and then interviews a key informant at each, usually the head clergyperson (Chaves, 2017). I pool the four waves fielded between 1998 and 2019. The second is the Cooperative Clergy Study Project (CCSP), a survey fielded in 2000 and 2017,

in which research teams each surveyed a sample of clergy drawn from the rosters of selected denominations (Smidt, 2004).

Because no survey asks directly about the four dimensions, I select for each the closest item that should correlate with it. For polity, I use the NCS item asking whether a representative of the denomination visited the congregation in the past year. Where authority above the congregation is real, its agents show up to supervise. For confession, I use pastors' agreement with the CCSP item "Jesus will return to earth one day."[6] I use this item in two ways. The level of agreement tests whether clergy hold what the confession specifies. The dispersion of agreement, each pastor's absolute deviation from the denomination's mean, tests whether the creed is binding, as a denomination whose clergy happen to agree is not the same as one whose clergy are held to an agreement, and only the second should show low dispersion. For ordination, I use whether the pastor holds a seminary degree and whether the congregation's leader was drawn from within the congregation, a hiring pattern that signals local control of the pulpit. Finally, I add two measures of institutional formality at the congregational level, including whether the congregation has a written budget and a governing board that met in the past year. These describe the congregation rather than the denomination, but institutionalized denominations often prescribe how congregations should be run, so congregation-level institutional formality is a trace of denominational rules reaching down.

Table 2 reports the results, with clergy-level controls for age and gender and congregation-level controls for size, racial composition, location, and years since founding. Overall, DII aligns well with how congregations actually operate. High-polity denominations are more likely to have hosted a denominational representative. Clergy in high-confession denominations affirm the return of Jesus at higher rates and vary less around their denomination's mean.

[6]Many belief items in the survey, such as biblical inerrancy, track the modernist-fundamentalist divide, a controversy that most confessional texts predate and do not adjudicate, so agreement on them would measure where a denomination sits theologically rather than whether its confession binds. The return of Christ is affirmed in the historic creeds and across the confessional texts, regardless of where they locate in the modernist-fundamentalist spectrum theologically.

Table 2: Validation: dimension scores against congregational and clergy behaviour

	A	B		C			DII	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Dependent variable	Denom. rep. hosted	Agrees *Jesus will return* (pastor)	SD of that agreement (denom.)	Seminary graduate (informant)	Seminary graduate (self-report)	Leader from inside congr.	Written budget	Board met
Institutionalization score (raw)	0.1324***	0.2026*	-0.2055*	0.0843***	0.1606**	-0.0727***	0.0125**	0.0095***
	(0.0290)	(0.0927)	(0.0959)	(0.0071)	(0.0475)	(0.0123)	(0.0033)	(0.0023)
Congregation-level controls	√	√	—	√	√	√	√	√
Clergy-level controls	—	√	—	—	√	—	—	—
Fixed effects	Division + year	Year	None	Division + year	State + year	Division + year	Division + year	Division + year
Observations	2,505	6,652	17	1,237	2,366	1,241	2,494	626
Denominations (clusters)	17	17	17	17	10	17	17	17
Data source	NCS	CCSP 2000	CCSP 2000	NCS	CCSP 2017	NCS	NCS	NCS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each column regresses the outcome on the score of the dimension or on the full DII in (7)–(8). NCS columns control for log adult participants, white share, and years since founding. CCSP columns control for log adult members, urban location, and pastor gender and age. Columns (2) and (3) use the same item, agreement that Jesus will return to earth one day. Column (2) is the pastor's own agreement. Column (3) is its dispersion within denomination, one observation per denomination and therefore without controls or clustering. All other standard errors are clustered on denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Table SI-4.

High-ordination clergy are more likely to hold seminary degrees and less likely to have been drawn from the congregation they lead. Congregations of high-DII denominations are more likely to run a written budget and to have convened their governing board.

The index should also leave an imprint on members' own religious life. An institutionalized body, as I argued above, supplies much of that life ready-made. Where denominations do not provide such resources to mediate the believer's relation to God, believers sustain that relation through practices they perform themselves. Institutionalization should therefore depress private devotion and direct religious experience while leaving communal engagement intact or raising it.

I test this with four measures of private devotion from the General Social Survey (1972–2022), supplemented by the Religious Landscape Study (2007 and 2014), a nationally representative Pew survey that asks a wider range of questions about religious life and belief. For private devotion, I use frequency of Scripture reading, frequency of prayer, born-again, and report of a life-changing religious experience. For communal participation I use seven measures: official membership, volunteering through the church, participation in church-affiliated groups, social activities, choir, youth work, and activities beyond regular services. Models control for attendance, importance of religion (in the GSS, strength of religious

Table 3: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior

Panel A: Private devotion

Dependent variable	(1) Reads scripture	(2) Reads scripture	(3) Prays	(4) Prays	(5) Born-again	(6) Born-again	(7) Rel. experience changed life
DII (0–12)	-0.0313**	-0.0413***	-0.0136**	-0.0278***	-0.0215***	-0.0253***	-0.0081*
	(0.0099)	(0.0059)	(0.0043)	(0.0041)	(0.0057)	(0.0042)	(0.0040)
Individual controls	√	√	√	√	√	√	√
Fixed effects	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year
Observations	1,299	28,129	16,664	28,079	10,221	27,594	4,343
Denominations	39	96	50	96	49	96	46
Data source	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS

Panel B: Congregational participation

Dependent variable	(8) Official member	(9) Volunteers through church	(10) Church-affiliated group member	(11) Social activities	(12) Choir or music	(13) Works with children	(14) Activities beyond services
DII (0–12)	0.0080***	0.0190***	0.0042**	0.0063*	0.0044	-0.0024	0.0055
	(0.0020)	(0.0033)	(0.0014)	(0.0028)	(0.0046)	(0.0039)	(0.0056)
Individual controls	√	√	√	√	√	√	√
Fixed effects	State + wave	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	State + wave	State + wave	Division + year
Observations	28,221	12,821	9,928	12,845	12,850	12,858	8,885
Denominations	96	93	48	93	93	93	49
Data source	RLS 2007+14	RLS 2007	GSS	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	GSS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Each column is a separate OLS regression of the outcome, on its native scale with higher values indicating more of the practice, on the raw DII (0–12). Controls are attendance, strength of affiliation (GSS) or importance of religion (RLS), ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, and race and Hispanic indicators, the latter dropped where it does not vary. Standard errors are clustered on denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-5–SI-6.

affiliation), ideology, partisanship, education, age, sex, race and ethnicity, with geographic and time fixed effects and standard errors clustered on denomination.

The split is as predicted. In Panel A, every form of private devotion declines with institutionalization. In Panel B, not one form of communal participation falls: membership, volunteering, involvement in church-affiliated groups, and attendance at church social activities all rise, and the rest are indistinguishable from zero. Believers in institutionalized denominations are not less attached to their churches. What they do less of is the practices one performs alone and holds directly.

In sum, the index tracks how denominations are governed and how believers practice. The next section moves to whether the index affects trust in authority-claiming institutions.

DII and Institutional Trust

I argue that members of more institutionalized churches exhibit greater trust in institutions, especially authority-claiming ones. I examine three categories of institutions. The first comprises national political institutions: the executive branch, Congress, the Supreme Court, and political parties. The second consists of local governments: mayors or city managers and city councils. The third encompasses non-political institutions tasked with producing and certifying knowledge: the scientific community, modern medicine, the education system (including separate evaluations of local public schools and universities), the news media, and organized religion itself.

To measure institutional trust, I draw on three data sources. The General Social Survey (GSS) has fielded a consistent confidence battery across five decades (1973 to 2022, as the 2024 release omits detailed denomination codes). While the American National Election Studies (ANES) covers fewer institutions, its feeling-thermometer series spans the three federal branches over the long run. The ANES 2024 wave further introduces trust items for the courts, political parties, the scientific community, the media, and higher education. Finally, the Cooperative Election Study (CES) is the only survey that contains evaluations of local political offices and schools, while the 2022 CES includes an item assessing trust in the federal government.[7] Wherever similar items appear across multiple surveys, I incorporate each variation to ensure that the empirical findings do not reflect artifacts of any single survey vehicle or question format.

Table 4 reports the results. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from one model, with the outcome standardized, because the response scales differ across surveys.[8] Every model controls for sex, age, race, ethnicity, education, family income, ideology, partisanship, and

[7]Appendix A.3 details how denominational DII scores are merged with respondents in each dataset.

[8]The GSS records whether respondents have a great deal of confidence, only some confidence, or hardly any confidence in the leaders of each institution. The ANES 1972 to 2024 cumulative file utilizes feeling thermometers of the institutions, ranging from 0 to 100. The ANES 2024 wave measures institutional trust on a four-point scale. The CES asks respondents to assign letter grades from A to F to specific local officials and municipal services.

Table 4: DII and confidence in individual institutions across three surveys

	GSS confidence 1973–2022	ANES thermometer 1980–2024	ANES 2024 trust (4-pt)	CES 2016 local rating / 2022 trust
1. National political branches				
Executive / federal government	0.0046* (0.0017), n=20,335	0.0073* (0.0035), n=5,826	0.0100* (0.0039), n=1,603	0.0118** (0.0037), n=13,212
Congress	0.0005 (0.0015), n=20,334	0.0014 (0.0033), n=9,862	0.0056 (0.0056), n=1,606	—
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0163*** (0.0031), n=20,074	0.0074*** (0.0015), n=9,257	0.0094 (0.0067), n=1,603	—
Political parties	—	—	0.0115* (0.0047), n=1,602	—
2. Local political bodies				
Mayor / city manager	—	—	—	0.0059*** (0.0016), n=14,146
City council	—	—	—	0.0043* (0.0019), n=14,265
3. Non-political bodies				
Organized religion	0.0143** (0.0049), n=20,161	—	—	—
Scientific community	0.0126** (0.0041), n=19,468	—	0.0065 (0.0051), n=1,605	—
Medicine	0.0108*** (0.0017), n=20,508	—	—	—
Press / traditional media	0.0093*** (0.0016), n=20,434	—	0.0178*** (0.0046), n=1,605	—
Television	0.0081** (0.0028), n=20,454	—	—	—
Education	0.0079** (0.0029), n=20,450	—	—	—
Colleges and universities	—	—	0.0134** (0.0048), n=1,763	—
Local schools	—	—	—	0.0079** (0.0028), n=15,330

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Every cell is the coefficient on the raw DII (0–12) with the outcome standardized, so cells are comparable as SD-per-DII-point. All models control for attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, Hispanic origin, and family income, with survey-year and state fixed effects (census division in the GSS, whose public release carries no state). Standard errors are clustered on the adult denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-7 and SI-8–SI-10.

religious attendance, with geographic fixed effects, survey-year fixed effects, and standard errors clustered on denomination. The results are consistent across the three groups of institutions. Members of highly institutionalized churches have more confidence in organized religion, and they extend that confidence to secular institutions: the federal executive, the Supreme Court,[9] political parties, the mayor and the city council, the press, the scientific community and medicine, and the education system from local schools through colleges and universities. The magnitudes are substantively meaningful. In the GSS models, the difference between a Southern Baptist and a Missouri Synod Lutheran, seven points on the index, moves confidence in the Supreme Court by about a tenth of a standard deviation, an effect slightly larger than that of a one-unit increase in the five-category education scale, roughly the distance from a high school graduate to a junior college degree, and moves confidence in the scientific community by about two-thirds as much. Congress is the one institution whose coefficient never separates from zero on any of the three trust measures that carry it.

One threat to a causal interpretation of the findings is sorting into denominations. As recent work has pointed out, the causal direction between religion and political attitudes runs both ways. Religion not only shapes political attitudes but is itself sometimes the product of political views (Margolis, 2018; Patrikios, 2008; Putnam and Campbell, 2010; Campbell et al., 2018). It is therefore possible that people who already trust institutions select into churches that run on credentials and procedure, while people with a more suspicious attitude toward institutional authority go to less institutionalized churches.

To address potential self-selection into denominations, I instrument for adult DII using the denomination in which the respondent was raised at age 16, leveraging the fact that this early affiliation was chosen by parents rather than by the respondent. This identification strategy is feasible only for the GSS, which has consistently tracked childhood religious denomination across five decades.

[9] In the ANES 2024 wave, the standardized judiciary coefficient (0.0094) lies between the GSS estimate (0.0163) and the ANES thermometer estimate (0.0074), so the point estimate is in line with the other two sources. But the module was fielded in a single wave, and at that sample size (n = 1,603) the coefficient cannot be separated from zero.

A causal interpretation of the IV estimates rests on the assumption that childhood denominational affiliation affects adult institutional trust solely through its influence on adult denominational choice, which is a demanding assumption. Unobserved household factors that shaped parental church affiliation might also have affected parenting styles and early political socialization. While this concern cannot be eliminated by design, it can be mitigated by controlling for observable characteristics of parents. I therefore control for a full childhood-background battery available in the GSS, including education levels of parents, relative family income at age 16, father's occupational prestige, community type (urban versus rural), and census division of upbringing. Controlling for this battery substantially attenuates confounding along observable socioeconomic dimensions, though it cannot fully neutralize unobserved channels, such as denominational doctrine shaping parental discipline. Therefore, the instrumented estimates should be interpreted not as point estimates of a single causal effect, but rather as evidence ruling out the specific concern of endogenous adult sorting into denominations.

Table 5 compares the OLS and instrumental-variable estimates. Each cell reports the DII coefficient from one model. Column 1 gives the OLS estimate, column 2 applies the instrumental-variable strategy, and column 3 adds strict controls for family background. All three columns are estimated on the same sample for each outcome, namely respondents with no missing value on any control variable. Differences across columns therefore cannot be produced by differences in sample. That sample is smaller than in Table 4 because father's occupational prestige and family income at 16 are frequently missing. Standard errors are clustered on adult denomination in column 1 and on childhood denomination in columns 2 and 3. The instrumented estimates tell the same story as the OLS estimates. Across institutions the coefficients move little when the DII is instrumented, and where they do move there is no general attenuation. Medicine rises, while the Supreme Court, organized religion, and television do not move. Confidence in the scientific community is unchanged under the instrument alone and attenuates by about a third once the background battery

Table 5: Childhood-DII instrumental-variables estimates (GSS)

Dependent variable	OLS	2SLS (naive)	2SLS + full childhood background battery	F	F (bg)	N
Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)						
Executive branch	0.0045***	0.0035†	0.0025	1175	1214	11,809
	(0.0013)	(0.0017)	(0.0019)			
Congress	0.0024†	-0.0012	-0.0008	1142	1184	11,810
	(0.0012)	(0.0023)	(0.0025)			
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0108***	0.0111***	0.0097***	1123	1163	11,690
	(0.0022)	(0.0029)	(0.0027)			
Organized religion	0.0097**	0.0092**	0.0091*	1118	1171	11,680
	(0.0033)	(0.0032)	(0.0035)			
Scientific community	0.0084***	0.0085**	0.0058*	1109	1132	11,342
	(0.0022)	(0.0027)	(0.0023)			
Medicine	0.0070***	0.0100***	0.0093***	1137	1192	11,872
	(0.0009)	(0.0019)	(0.0018)			
Education	0.0063**	0.0034†	0.0043*	1157	1198	11,856
	(0.0022)	(0.0019)	(0.0021)			
Press	0.0056***	0.0042	0.0032	1193	1253	11,837
	(0.0014)	(0.0027)	(0.0026)			
Television	0.0050**	0.0051*	0.0056*	1162	1207	11,839
	(0.0017)	(0.0025)	(0.0023)			

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants raised Protestant, GSS 1973–2022. The instrument is the DII of the denomination in which the respondent was raised at age 16. All three columns control for attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, Hispanic origin, and log real family income, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. The third column adds the childhood-background battery, parental education, relative family income at 16, father's occupational prestige, and type of place lived in at 16, with fixed effects for the census division of upbringing. All three columns are estimated on the same complete-case sample, so nothing in a row moves because of who is in the sample. F and F(bg) are the cluster-robust first-stage F statistics on the excluded instrument. Standard errors are clustered on the childhood denomination, the level at which the instrument varies, in the 2SLS columns, and on the adult denomination in the OLS column. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-11–SI-13.

enters, but remains significant. The press and the executive branch are the exceptions. Both point estimates fall and neither can be separated from zero under the instrument, but the standard errors roughly double at the same time, so these estimates cannot be distinguished from their OLS counterparts either. Congress, marginal in the OLS to begin with, falls to zero under the instrument, consistent with its null throughout Table 4.

DII and Populism

I next move from trust in particular institutions to more general anti-establishment and populist sentiments. Populism rests on distrust in institutions and elites who run them (Rooduijn, 2018; Uscinski et al., 2021), depicting the world as divided between "the people" and detached, corrupt, and self-serving "the elite" (Mudde, 2004; Müller, 2016). The literature on populism has traditionally centered on attitudes toward politicians, but recent work has observed that anti-establishment sentiment is not confined to those who hold political power but also extends to those who control knowledge production, the experts (Oliver and Rahn, 2016; Merkley, 2020).

I turn to the ANES to test the association between the DII and populist attitudes. The first battery, in Panel A, concerns the government as a whole and the officials who run it. Questions include whether hardly any officials are crooked, whether the government is run for the benefit of all or by a few big interests, whether it can be trusted to do what is right, and whether it wastes tax money. These are the standard ANES trust-in-government items, carried in the cumulative file for five decades. Estimation begins in 1972, the first year the ANES asked about ideology, which serves as an important control variable.[10] The second battery, in Panel B, asks about politicians as a class. It was fielded in 2016 and 2020, which I pool. The items cover whether the people rather than politicians should decide policy, whether politicians care what people like the respondent think, whether politicians

[10]Two of the four items were retired after 2012, so Panel A mixes series running to 2012 with series running to 2024.

are the main problem in the country, whether they serve only the rich and powerful, whether compromise amounts to selling out, and whether most politicians can be trusted. The final two items, in Panel C, fielded in the 2020 ANES, concern experts rather than government or politicians: whether the respondent trusts experts more than ordinary people, and whether ordinary people need the help of experts.

Table 6 reports the results. Members of more institutionalized denominations extend more credit to the establishment. In Panel A all four coefficients are positive and significant. In Panel B, high-DII respondents are less likely to endorse the populist statements, rejecting the claims that politicians do not care what people like them think and that compromise amounts to selling out, and they are more likely to agree that most politicians can be trusted, the one item in the battery whose endorsement runs against the populist position. Panel C extends the disposition from political to epistemic authority: the same respondents trust experts over ordinary people, and the second expert item points the same way but does not separate from zero. Institutionalization does not merely predict confidence in particular institutions. It predicts rejection of the populist frame itself, whether the elite in question holds office or holds knowledge.

The literature often links the rise of right-wing populism to nativism or racism (Mutz, 2018; Berman, 2021; Mudde, 2007). The disposition the DII produces, however, does not extend to either. Across the ten nativism and racial-resentment items the CES carries, only two coefficients reach significance in the inclusive direction: members of more institutionalized churches are less likely to support increasing border patrols and less likely to deny that slavery created lasting conditions. The other eight cannot be distinguished from zero, so the evidence on this side is thinner than on the anti-elite items (Appendix Table SI-16). Low institutionalization produces a disposition toward institutional authority, not the full populist package.

Table 6: DII and populist sentiment about politicians and government (ANES)

Dependent variable	Coef.	(SE)	N	Denoms.	Years
A. Officials and elite capture (cumulative file; higher = the trusting response)					
Hardly any officials are crooked (1–3)	0.0072***	(0.0016)	11,509	63	1972–2012
Government run for the benefit of all (0/1)	0.0039***	(0.0008)	15,695	67	1972–2024
Trusts government to do what is right (1–4)	0.0053*	(0.0023)	11,248	61	1972–2012
Government does not waste tax money (1–3)	0.0047***	(0.0008)	16,287	68	1972–2024
B. The people-vs-politicians battery (2016 + 2020 pooled; higher = agrees)					
People, not politicians, should decide policy (1–5)	-0.0087	(0.0052)	4,006	52	2016+2020
Most politicians do not care about the people (1–5)	-0.0108**	(0.0034)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Politicians are the main problem in the U.S. (1–5)	0.0009	(0.0054)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Politicians care only about the rich and powerful (1–5)	-0.0105	(0.0063)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Compromise in politics is selling out (1–5)	-0.0163**	(0.0060)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Most politicians are trustworthy (1–5)	0.0109***	(0.0028)	4,010	52	2016+2020
C. Experts versus the people (2020; higher = defers to experts)					
Trusts experts more than ordinary people (1–5)	0.0061*	(0.0030)	2,722	48	2020
Ordinary people need experts' help (1–5)	0.0066	(0.0040)	2,724	48	2020

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Each row reports the coefficient on the DII (0–12) from a separate OLS regression, with the outcome on its native scale. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, Hispanic origin, and family income, with survey-year and state fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on the denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-8 and SI-15.

From Attitudes to Behavior: County-Level Evidence

Finally, I examine whether the institutional trust and pro-establishment attitudes of high-DII members stop at the survey or carry into behavior. Here I leave individual survey data for county-level evidence.

The first behavioral outcome is the vote. A large literature reads Trump's rise as an expression of anti-institutional and anti-establishment sentiment (Mutz, 2018; Sides, Tesler and Vavreck, 2018). The general-election vote, however, is a poor measure of that sentiment. Most voters voted the party line, and a Trump ballot cannot distinguish those who supported him because of his break with the establishment from those who supported him despite it. I therefore focus on the 2016 Republican primary, where party is held constant and the anti-establishment candidate ran against copartisan alternatives drawn from the party establishment. A county's Trump share in that contest measures the willingness of Republican voters to reject their own party's establishment (MacWilliams, 2016; Rothwell and Diego-

Rosell, 2016; Monnat and Brown, 2017; Bursztyn, Egorov and Fiorin, 2020).

The second outcome is the COVID-19 vaccination rate. Populism is not confined to the political domain, and the disposition that rejects the political class often extends to experts. During the pandemic, suspicion of scientific consensus and of public health expertise translated into refusal of a vaccine that medical authority endorsed (Kennedy, 2019; Mede and Schäfer, 2020), a costly act that carried real risk to the refuser's own health.

I use county-level returns from the 2016 Republican presidential primary, compiled from CNN's reported results (Hamner, 2016), and the county full-vaccination rate as of December 2021, compiled by the Bansal Lab from CDC county data and state health-department dashboards (Tiu et al., 2022).[11]

I then use the 2010 U.S. Religion Census (Grammich, 2012), which reports congregations and adherents by county for the 85 Protestant bodies, to construct a county-level Protestant DII: the adherent-weighted mean of the DII scores of the denominations present in the county, so a county of Episcopalians and Missouri Synod Lutherans scores high and a county of independent Baptist and nondenominational congregations scores low.

The baseline specification, columns 1 and 4 of Table 7, includes a battery of demographic controls from the U.S. Census Bureau (2026) and the MIT Election Data and Science Lab (2018): the shares white, Hispanic, foreign born, without a four-year degree, below the poverty line, unemployed, rural, and over 65, log median household income, and log population density, together with the county's Protestant and Catholic adherence rates from the Religion Census (Grammich, 2012). It also includes total frontier experience (Bazzi, Fiszbein and Gebresilasse, 2020) and state fixed effects. Frontier individualism may produce populism directly, and it may also have produced the religious ecology in which low-DII Protestantism thrives, since the frontier is where the itinerant preachers of the upstart denominations found their audience (Hatch, 1989; Finke and Stark, 2005). Columns 2 and 5 add nine European-ancestry shares

[11]The primary returns cover 39 states. The rest held no primary vote, did not report results by county, or reported by town. The vaccination rate is each county's last report on or before December 31, 2021, when every adult had been eligible for eight months.

Table 7: County religious composition, the 2016 primary, and vaccination

	Trump 2016 GOP-primary share (pp)			Full vaccination rate, Dec. 2021 (pp)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
County DII (index points)	-0.6799***	-0.5870**	-0.5754**	0.7713**	0.9766***	0.7448**
	(0.1771)	(0.1832)	(0.1808)	(0.2497)	(0.2281)	(0.2301)
% Protestant adherents	-0.0980***	-0.0855***	-0.0876***	-0.0371†	-0.0149	0.0246
	(0.0131)	(0.0144)	(0.0157)	(0.0208)	(0.0255)	(0.0266)
% Catholic adherents	0.0344†	0.0021	0.0026	0.0466†	0.0414	0.0586*
	(0.0201)	(0.0207)	(0.0208)	(0.0257)	(0.0299)	(0.0230)
% white	0.0308	0.0334	0.0189	-0.2047***	-0.2086***	0.1384**
	(0.0242)	(0.0275)	(0.0274)	(0.0236)	(0.0317)	(0.0438)
% Hispanic	-0.1216***	-0.1072***	-0.1098**	0.0988**	0.1117**	0.1800***
	(0.0274)	(0.0299)	(0.0318)	(0.0304)	(0.0344)	(0.0365)
% foreign born	0.2292*	0.2137†	0.2057†	-0.1098†	-0.1197*	0.0614
	(0.0987)	(0.1068)	(0.1019)	(0.0560)	(0.0541)	(0.0622)
% non-college	0.3880***	0.3739***	0.3661***	-0.5451***	-0.5442***	-0.1551***
	(0.0442)	(0.0454)	(0.0430)	(0.0759)	(0.0701)	(0.0400)
Log median income	-0.9538	-2.0450	-2.2630	-0.7874	-0.8175	4.3150*
	(1.8902)	(1.6663)	(1.7789)	(2.2408)	(2.3164)	(1.9137)
% below poverty	0.0879*	0.0631†	0.0657†	-0.1838*	-0.1966*	-0.1974*
	(0.0393)	(0.0331)	(0.0354)	(0.0909)	(0.0890)	(0.0875)
% unemployed	0.3059***	0.2279**	0.2282**	0.2397†	0.1716	0.1506
	(0.0806)	(0.0827)	(0.0836)	(0.1210)	(0.1126)	(0.1088)
% rural	-0.0168	-0.0063	-0.0056	0.0091	0.0120	-0.0008
	(0.0102)	(0.0099)	(0.0100)	(0.0167)	(0.0148)	(0.0089)
% age 65+	0.3740***	0.3524***	0.3599***	0.4927***	0.4842***	0.3735***
	(0.0633)	(0.0624)	(0.0595)	(0.0615)	(0.0584)	(0.0668)
Log population density	-0.6610*	-0.8043*	-0.7519*	1.6829**	1.6199***	0.1365
	(0.2865)	(0.3023)	(0.3312)	(0.5003)	(0.4263)	(0.2373)
Romney 2012 vote share	—	—	0.0225	—	—	—
			(0.0448)			
Trump 2020 vote share	—	—	—	—	—	-0.4874***
						(0.0567)
Frontier TFE (decades)	-0.1895	-0.1947	-0.2001	0.1240	0.0673	0.1020
	(0.2188)	(0.1968)	(0.2033)	(0.1851)	(0.1610)	(0.1277)
Nine European-ancestry shares	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Prior-vote baseline	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
State fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,732	2,732	2,732	3,079	3,079	3,079
States (clusters)	43	43	43	44	44	44
DV mean	47.0	47.0	47.0	47.7	47.7	47.7
DV SD	15.7	15.7	15.7	12.5	12.5	12.5

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Columns 2, 3, 5, and 6 add nine European-ancestry shares, not shown. Columns 3 and 6 add the county's prior Republican vote share: the Romney 2012 general-election share for the primary outcome and the Trump 2020 share for the vaccination outcome. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by state.

from the Census Bureau, because a county's denominational composition is in part a residue of where immigrant groups settled: Germans and Scandinavians went to the Lutheran synods, the Dutch to the Reformed churches, and the Scots-Irish to Presbyterianism. Settlement of this kind leaves its own imprint on political culture (Fischer, 1989; Lieske, 1993; Rice and Feldman, 1997; Jaworski and Kimbrough, 2026), so the ancestry shares absorb what the county DII would otherwise pick up from ethnic origin. Columns 3 and 6 add the county's prior Republican vote share, the Romney 2012 general-election share for the primary outcome (MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2018) and the Trump 2020 share for the vaccination outcome (McGovern, 2024).

A county whose Protestant adherents belong to more institutionalized bodies gave a smaller share of its Republican primary vote to Trump and had vaccinated more of its residents by December 2021. A one-standard-deviation difference in the county DII, 1.8 points, implies a Trump share 1.0 percentage points lower and a vaccination rate 1.3 percentage points higher in columns 3 and 6, the most stringent specifications, which include the prior Republican vote share. What institutionalized religious life shapes is not only expressed attitudes but revealed preferences.

Robustness Checks and Additional Analysis

I conduct several additional analyses. First, if members learn institutional trust inside institutionalized churches, the association should be strongest for the members most exposed to church life, the most frequent church attendees. I interact the DII with church attendance, which is used as a control in the main specification, in every individual-level model of Tables 4 and 6, with the outcome and attendance standardized, and report the full grid in Appendix Tables SI-17 and SI-18. For confidence in specific institutions the dose is strong and consistent: seven of the nine GSS interactions are positive and significant. For the populist battery the evidence is thinner. The coefficients are small, with only one term marginally significant. One

reading of the contrast is that participation transmits a template for judging institutional authority rather than an affect toward politicians as a class, so the judgments deepen with exposure while the sentiment does not.

Although the main focus is Protestants, I extend the analysis to Catholics in Appendix E. Catholics' historical relationship with American institutions was complicated by societal and institutional discrimination and by direct conflict between secular and religious authority, especially before Vatican II, when the Church had not yet accepted the separation of church and state (McGreevy, 2003; Casanova, 1994). The results show a trust deficit among older cohorts, who carried the memory of exclusion, that narrows or reverses among younger generations. One exception is organized religion, where the gap between younger Catholics and Protestants is larger, potentially reflecting exposure to the abuse scandals of the Catholic Church in recent decades.

One potential challenge is that the DII records only the difference between theologically conservative and liberal Protestants, the division the literature codes as evangelical versus mainline (Steensland et al., 2000). Although both camps are diverse in their organizational structures,[12] the evangelical camp leans toward the less institutionalized end and the mainline camp toward the more institutionalized end. Directly controlling for the denominational evangelical-mainline division, however, cannot separate the two, because the standard coding, RelTrad, bundles theological conservatism with institutional form. It grounds the distinction in part on a denomination's origin in a church-like or a sect-like movement (Steensland et al., 2000, 293–297).

I therefore turn to individual-level measures of theological conservatism: born-again self-identification, an individual-level operationalization of evangelicalism that performs comparably to the denominational coding (Burge and Lewis, 2018), and biblical literalism,

[12]Evangelical bodies do lean toward the low-institutional end and mainline bodies toward the high, but each camp spans the range. The evangelical camp contains denominations descended from the Reformation, such as the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod and the Presbyterian Church in America, alongside congregationally governed revivalist bodies, such as the Southern Baptist Convention. The mainline camp ranges from congregational bodies, such as the Disciples and the United Church of Christ, to the most hierarchical Protestant churches in the country, the Episcopalians and the United Methodists.

the view that the Bible is the actual word of God and is to be taken literally, word for word. I use the two measures in two ways. First, I rerun the individual-level models of Tables 4 and 6, controlling for each measure separately and for both together (Appendix Tables SI-19 and SI-20). The results barely move, and nearly every coefficient that is significant in the main tables survives. Second, I divide the sample by the answers to the two questions and estimate the models separately among born-again and other Protestants and among literalists and non-literalists (Appendix Tables SI-21 and SI-22). The confidence estimates persist among theological conservatives and are often larger there than in the full sample. The populism estimates lose precision in the smaller subgroups, though most keep their sign.

I conduct two further sensitivity checks. First, not every respondent can be matched to an exact denominational body. Some report only a denominational family (Lutheran, Pentecostal, or Holiness) without naming the body, and this is especially common in the earlier GSS waves, whose denomination codes are coarser. Rather than discard these respondents, I assign them the score of their family's largest body, and the appendix describes the assignment in full. As a check, I re-estimate the individual-level models on the years in which the surveys probe specific denominational bodies, 1984 and later in the GSS and 1990 and later in the ANES, a restriction defined by the survey's coding rather than by the respondents' answers. The estimates are unchanged or slightly stronger (Appendix Table SI-25).

Second, I exclude the nondenominational churches, a heterogeneous set of congregations that sits at the bottom of the index. Because these churches anchor the low end, the results could in principle reflect a single contrast between nondenominational and denominational Protestantism rather than a gradient running across denominations. Dropping the cell leaves the main results intact (Appendix Table SI-26). The headline coefficients grow slightly rather than shrink, and the only casualties are a few cells that lose precision as the sample thins.

Conclusion

This paper examines how the organization of religious authority in a church shapes its members' political attitudes and behavior. In denominations where authority is mediated by written constitutions, binding confessions, ordination credentials, and disciplinary machinery, members extend more trust to secular institutions, from the federal executive and the Supreme Court to local government, the scientific community, and medicine. They are less likely to hold populist anti-establishment sentiments, whether the elite in question holds office or holds knowledge. Using aggregate-level data, I show that counties whose Protestants belong to more institutionalized bodies gave a smaller share of their 2016 Republican primary vote to the anti-establishment candidate and had higher vaccination rates during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Two directions are left for future work. First, a long literature holds that the form of associational life shapes general social trust, not only trust in institutions (Putnam, Leonardi and Nanetti, 1993; Stolle and Rochon, 1998). Whether the disposition documented here extends from institutions to strangers is the natural next question. Second, the paper measures one religious family in one country. Across the world's religious traditions, the organization of religious authority varies far more widely than it does within American Protestantism. Future work that applies the conceptual and coding scheme of this project across traditions would turn a claim about American Protestants into a claim about religion and institutional life in general.

The finding carries an important implication. The American religious landscape has been moving toward de-institutionalization: institutionalized denominations, both mainline and conservative, have contracted for two generations, while the nondenominational and loosely affiliated congregations have grown (Chaves, 2017). This shift in the religious field is not only a matter for churchgoers but also a matter for American democracy. As institutionalized churches decline, fewer Americans will have the chance to learn to accept the authority of institutions that stand between the popular will and its enactment.

References

Ambrosius, Joshua D. 2011. "Religion, politics, and polity replication: Religious differences in preferences for institutional design." *Interdisciplinary Journal of Research on Religion* 7(9).

Arzheimer, Kai and Elisabeth Carter. 2009. "Christian religiosity and voting for West European radical right parties." *West European Politics* 32(5):985–1011.

Barker, David C. and James D. Tinnick, III. 2006. "Competing visions of parental roles and ideological constraint." *American Political Science Review* 100(2):249–263.

Bazzi, Samuel, Martin Fiszbein and Mesay Gebresilasse. 2020. "Frontier Culture: The Roots and Persistence of "Rugged Individualism" in the United States." *Econometrica : journal of the Econometric Society* 88(6):2329–2368.

Bellin, Eva. 2008. "Faith in politics: New trends in the study of religion and politics." *World Politics* 60(2):315–347.

Ben-Nun Bloom, Pazit and Gizem Arikan. 2012. "A two-edged sword: The differential effect of religious belief and religious social context on attitudes towards democracy." *Political Behavior* 34(2):249–276.

Ben-Nun Bloom, Pazit and Gizem Arikan. 2013. "Religion and support for democracy: a cross-national test of the mediating mechanisms." *British Journal of Political Science* 43(2):375–397.

Berman, Sheri. 2021. "The causes of populism in the west." *Annual Review of Political Science* 24(1):71–88.

Bonomi, Patricia U. 1986. *Under the cope of heaven: Religion, society, and politics in colonial america*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Brehm, John and Wendy Rahn. 1997. "Individual-Level Evidence for the Causes and Consequences of Social Capital." *American Journal of Political Science* 41(3):999–1023.

Burge, Ryan P and Andrew R Lewis. 2018. "Measuring Evangelicals: Practical Considerations forSocial Scientists." *Politics and Religion* 11(4):745–759.

Bursztyn, Leonardo, Georgy Egorov and Stefano Fiorin. 2020. "From Extreme to Mainstream: The Erosion of Social Norms." *American Economic Review* 110(11):3522–3548.

Butler, Jon. 1990. *Awash in a sea of faith: Christianizing the american people*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Campbell, David E. 2004. "Acts of Faith: Churches and Political Engagement." *Political Behavior* 26(2):155–180.

Campbell, David E. 2008. "Voice in the classroom: How an open classroom climate fosters political engagement among adolescents." *Political Behavior* 30(4):437–454.

Campbell, David E., Geoffrey C. Layman, John C. Green and Nathanael G. Sumaktoyo. 2018. "Putting Politics First: The Impact of Politics on American Religious and Secular Orientations." *American Journal of Political Science* 62(3):551–565.

Casanova, José. 1994. *Public religions in the modern world*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Chaves, Mark. 1993. "Denominations as dual structures: An organizational analysis." *Sociology of Religion* 54(2):147–169.

Chaves, Mark. 1997. *Ordaining women: Culture and conflict in religious organizations*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Chaves, Mark. 2017. *American religion: Contemporary trends*. 2 ed. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Citrin, Jack and Laura Stoker. 2018. "Political Trust in a Cynical Age." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21:49–70.

Clark, Cory, Calvin Isch, Jim Everett and Azim Shariff. 2023. "Politicization undermines trust in institutions, even among the ideologically aligned public.".

Cremer, Tobias. 2023. *The godless crusade: Religion, populism and right-wing identity politics in the West*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

DeCanio, Samuel. 2007. "Religion and Nineteenth-Century Voting Behavior: A New Look at Some Old Data." *The Journal of Politics* 69(2):339–350.

Devine, Daniel and Viktor Orri Valgarðsson. 2024. "Stability and change in political trust: Evidence and implications from six panel studies." *European Journal of Political Research* 63(2):478–497.

Devine, Daniel, Viktor Valgarðsson, Jessica Smith, Will Jennings, Michele Scotto di Vettimo, Hannah Bunting and Lawrence McKay. 2024. "Political trust in the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic: a meta-analysis of 67 studies." *Journal of European Public Policy* 31(3):657–679.

Djupe, Paul A. and Christopher P. Gilbert. 2006. "The resourceful believer: Generating civic skills in church." *The Journal of Politics* 68(1):116–127.

Djupe, Paul A. and Christopher P. Gilbert. 2009. *The political influence of churches*. Cambridge studies in social theory, religion and politics New York: Cambridge University Press.

Edwards, Jeffrey R and Richard P Bagozzi. 2000. "On the nature and direction of relationships between constructs and measures." *Psychological methods* 5(2):155.

Einstein, Katherine Levine and David M. Glick. 2015. "Do I Think BLS Data are BS? The Consequences of Conspiracy Theories." *Political Behavior* 37(3):679–701.

Evans, John H. 2011. "Epistemological and Moral Conflict Between Religion and Science." *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 50(4):707–727.

Finke, Roger and Rodney Stark. 2005. *The churching of america, 1776–2005: Winners and losers in our religious economy*. 2 ed. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press.

Fischer, David Hackett. 1989. *Albion's seed: Four British folkways in America*. Vol. 1 America: A Cultural History.

Freitag, Markus and Kathrin Ackermann. 2016. "Direct Democracy and Institutional Trust: Relationships and Differences Across Personality Traits." *Political Psychology* 37(5):707–723.

Gallup. 2026. "Confidence in U.S. institutions remains near all-time low.".
URL: *https://news.gallup.com/poll/712436/confidence-institutions-remains-near-time-low.aspx*

Gill, Anthony. 2001. "Religion and comparative politics." *Annual Review of Political Science* 4:117–138.

Goertz, Gary. 2006. *Social science concepts: a user's guide*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Grammich, Clifford Anthony. 2012. *2010 US religion census: Religious congregations & membership study: An enumeration by nation, state, and county based on data reported for 236 religious groups*. Association of Statisticians of American Religious Bodies.

Grzymała-Busse, Anna. 2012. "Why comparative politics should take religion (more) seriously." *Annual Review of Political Science* 15:421–442.

Grzymała-Busse, Anna. 2015. *Nations under god: How churches use moral authority to influence policy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Grzymała-Busse, Anna. 2023. *Sacred foundations: The religious and medieval roots of the european state*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Guriev, Sergei, Nikita Melnikov and Ekaterina Zhuravskaya. 2021. "3G Internet and Confidence in Government." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 136(4):2533–2613.

Hakhverdian, Armen and Quinton Mayne. 2012. "Institutional Trust, Education, and Corruption: A Micro-Macro Interactive Approach." *The Journal of Politics* 74(3):739–750.

Hamner, Ben. 2016. "2016 US election: County-level primary results.".
URL: *https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/benhamner/2016-us-election*

Harrison, Paul M. 1959. *Authority and power in the free church tradition: a social case study of the american baptist convention*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Hatch, Nathan O. 1989. *The democratization of american christianity*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.

Hooghe, Marc and Ruth Dassonneville. 2018. "A Spiral of Distrust: A Panel Study on the Relation between Political Distrust and Protest Voting in Belgium." *Government and Opposition* 53(1):104–130.

Iannaccone, Laurence R. 1994. "Why strict churches are strong." *American Journal of Sociology* 99(5):1180–1211.

Im, Hyug Baeg. 2020. Christian Churches and Democratization in South Korea BT - Democratization and Democracy in South Korea, 1960–Present. Singapore: Springer Singapore pp. 95–115.

Invernizzi, Giovanna M and Ahmed Ezzeldin Mohamed. 2023. "Trust nobody: How voters react to conspiracy theories." *Journal of Experimental Political Science* 10(2):201–208.

Jaworski, Taylor and Erik O Kimbrough. 2026. The Emergence of Regional Cultures in the United States. Technical report National Bureau of Economic Research.

Johnson, Benton. 1963. "On church and sect." *American Sociological Review* 28(4):539–549.

Kalyvas, Stathis N. 1996. *The rise of christian democracy in europe*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Kasselstrand, Isabella, Tiana Couse and Shanell Sanchez. 2017. "Institutional confidence in the United States: Attitudes of secular Americans." *Secularism and Nonreligion* 6:6.

Kelley, Dean M. 1972. *Why conservative churches are growing: a study in sociology of religion*. New York: Harper & Row.

Kennedy, Jonathan. 2019. "Populist Politics and Vaccine Hesitancy in Western Europe: An Analysis of National-Level Data." *European Journal of Public Health* 29(3):512–516.

Kohn, Melvin L. 1969. *Class and conformity: a study in values*. Homewood, IL: Dorsey Press.

Kohn, Melvin L. and Carmi Schooler. 1982. "Job conditions and personality: a longitudinal assessment of their reciprocal effects." *American Journal of Sociology* 87(6):1257–1286.

Kumlin, Staffan. 2004. The Personal and the Political. In *The Personal and the Political: How Personal Welfare State Experiences Affect Political Trust and Ideology*, ed. Staffan Kumlin. New York: Palgrave Macmillan US pp. 3–19.

Layman, Geoffrey. 2001. *The great divide: Religious and cultural conflict in american party politics*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Lieske, Joel. 1993. "Regional subcultures of the United States." *The Journal of Politics* 55(4):888–913.

Lipset, Seymour Martin and Stein Rokkan. 1967. Cleavage structures, party systems, and voter alignments: An introduction. In *Party systems and voter alignments: Cross-national perspectives*, ed. Seymour Martin Lipset and Stein Rokkan. New York: Free Press pp. 1–64.

Lizardo, Omar. 2017. "Improving cultural analysis: Considering personal culture in its declarative and nondeclarative modes." *American Sociological Review* 82(1):88–115.

Lorenz-Spreen, Philipp, Lisa Oswald, Stephan Lewandowsky and Ralph Hertwig. 2023. "A systematic review of worldwide causal and correlational evidence on digital media and democracy." *Nature Human Behaviour* 7(1):74–101.

MacWilliams, Matthew C. 2016. "Who Decides When the Party Doesn't? Authoritarian Voters and the Rise of Donald Trump." *PS: Political Science & Politics* 49(4):716–721.

Marcinkiewicz, Kamil and Ruth Dassonneville. 2022. "Do religious voters support populist radical right parties? Opposite effects in Western and East-Central Europe." *Party Politics* 28(3):444–456.

Margolis, Michele F. 2018. *From Politics to the Pews: How Partisanship and the Political Environment Shape Religious Identity*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Margolis, Michele F. 2020. "Who wants to make America great again? Understanding evangelical support for Donald Trump." *Politics and Religion* 13(1):89–118.

Marien, Sofie and Marc Hooghe. 2011. "Does political trust matter? An empirical investigation into the relation between political trust and support for law compliance." *European Journal of Political Research* 50(2):267–291.

McClendon, Gwyneth H. and Rachel Beatty Riedl. 2019. *From pews to politics: Religious sermons and political participation in africa*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

McClendon, Gwyneth and Rachel Beatty Riedl. 2015. "Religion as a stimulant of political participation: Experimental evidence from Nairobi, Kenya." *The Journal of Politics* 77(4):1045–1057.

McDaniel, Eric L. 2008. *Politics in the pews: The political mobilization of black churches*. The politics of race and ethnicity Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.

McGovern, Tony. 2024. "United states general election presidential results by district, ward, or county from 2008 to 2024.". tex.howpublished: GitHub repository.
URL: *https://github.com/tonmcg/US*$_{C}ounty_{L}evel_{E}lection_{R}esults_{0}8-24$

McGreevy, John T. 2003. *Catholicism and American Freedom: A History*. W. W. Norton & Company. Google-Books-ID: Tv93eR6f1nUC.

Mede, Niels G. and Mike S. Schäfer. 2020. "Science-Related Populism: Conceptualizing Populist Demands toward Science." *Public Understanding of Science* 29(5):473–491.

Melton, J. Gordon. 2009. *Melton's encyclopedia of american religions*. 8 ed. Detroit: Gale Cengage.

Merkley, Eric. 2020. "Anti-intellectualism, populism, and motivated resistance to expert consensus." *Public Opinion Quarterly* 84(1):24–48.

Miller, Donald E. 1997. *Reinventing american protestantism: Christianity in the new millennium*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Mishler, William and Richard Rose. 1997. "Trust, Distrust and Skepticism: Popular Evaluations of Civil and Political Institutions in Post-Communist Societies." *The Journal of Politics* 59(2):418–451.

MIT Election Data and Science Lab. 2018. "Election context 2018.".
URL: *https://github.com/MEDSL/2018-elections-unofficial*

Mondak, Jeffery J. and Karen D. Halperin. 2008. "A Framework for the Study of Personality and Political Behaviour." *British Journal of Political Science* 38(2):335–362.

Monnat, Shannon M. and David L. Brown. 2017. "More than a Rural Revolt: Landscapes of Despair and the 2016 Presidential Election." *Journal of Rural Studies* 55:227–236.

Morris, Aldon D. 1984. *The origins of the civil rights movement: Black communities organizing for change*. New York: Free Press.

Mudde, Cas. 2004. "The Populist Zeitgeist." *Government and Opposition* 39(4):541–563.

Mudde, Cas. 2007. *Populist radical right parties in Europe*. Vol. 22 Cambridge university press Cambridge.

Murtin, Fabrice, David Pipke, Gianluca Grimalda, Julien Bonnet, Lara Fleischer, Santiago Gonzalez, Vincent Siegerink, Arnstein Aassve, Yann Algan, Sophie Cetre, Matteo Galizzi, Rafael Hortala-Vallve, Soonhee Kim, Taejun (David) Lee, Zsuzsanna Lonti, Ogaki Masao, Louis Putterman, Ulrich Schmidt and Conal Smith. 2026. "What explains trust in institutions? Multi-disciplinary evidence from an international survey." *European Journal of Political Research* pp. 1–25.

Mutz, Diana C. 2018. "Status Threat, not Economic Hardship, explains the 2016 Presidential Vote." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 115(19):E4330–E4339.

Müller, J.W. 2016. *What Is Populism?* University of Pennsylvania Press, Incorporated.

Nye, Joseph S, Philip D Zelikow and David C King. 1997. *Why people don't trust government*. Harvard University Press.

Oliver, J. Eric and Wendy M. Rahn. 2016. "Rise of the Trumpenvolk: Populism in the 2016 Election." *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 667(1):189–206.

Patrikios, Stratos. 2008. "American Republican Religion? Disentangling the Causal Link between Religion and Politics in the US." *Political Behavior* 30(3):367–389.

Perry, Samuel L., Joseph O. Baker and Joshua B. Grubbs. 2021. "Ignorance or culture war? Christian nationalism and scientific illiteracy." *Public Understanding of Science* 30(8):930–946.

Pew Research Center. 2025. "Public trust in government: 1958–2025.". **URL:** *https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2025/12/04/public-trust-in-government-1958-2025/*

Philpott, Daniel. 2007. "Explaining the political ambivalence of religion." *American Political Science Review* 101(3):505–525.

Putnam, Robert D. and David E. Campbell. 2010. *American Grace: How Religion Divides and Unites Us*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

Putnam, Robert D., Robert Leonardi and Raffaella Y. Nanetti. 1993. *Making Democracy Work: Civic Traditions in Modern Italy*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Rice, Tom W and Jan L Feldman. 1997. "Civic culture and democracy from Europe to America." *the Journal of Politics* 59(4):1143–1172.

Rooduijn, Matthijs. 2018. "What unites the voter bases of populist parties? Comparing the electorates of 15 populist parties." *European Political Science Review* 10(3):351–368.

Rothwell, Jonathan T. and Pablo Diego-Rosell. 2016. "Explaining Nationalist Political Views: The Case of Donald Trump.". tex.howpublished: SSRN Working Paper 2822059.

Rubin, Jared. 2017. *Rulers, religion, and riches: Why the west got rich and the middle east did not*. Cambridge studies in economics, choice, and society Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Rubinstein, Murray A. 2015. The Presbyterian Church in the formation of Taiwan's democratic society, 1945–2004. In *Religious organizations and democratization*. Routledge pp. 109–134.

Schrøder, Thor Bech. 2023. "Don't Tell Me What I Don't Want to Hear! Politicization and Ideological Conflict Explain Why Citizens Have Lower Trust in Climate Scientists and Economists Than in Other Natural Scientists." *Political Psychology* 44(5):961–981.

Sewell, Jr., William H. 1992. "A theory of structure: Duality, agency, and transformation." *American Journal of Sociology* 98(1):1–29.

Sherkat, Darren E. 2011. "Religion and Scientific Literacy in the United States." *Social Science Quarterly* 92(5):1134–1150.

Sides, John, Michael Tesler and Lynn Vavreck. 2018. *Identity Crisis: The 2016 Presidential Campaign and the Battle for the Meaning of America*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Smidt, Corwin E., ed. 2004. *Pulpit and politics: Clergy in american politics at the advent of the millennium*. Waco, TX: Baylor University Press.

Smith, C. and M. Emerson. 1998. *American Evangelicalism: Embattled and Thriving*. American Evangelicalism: Embattled and Thriving University of Chicago Press.

Smith, Christian. 1996. *Disruptive religion: The force of faith in social movement activism*. New York: Routledge.

Smith, Gregory A., Alan Cooperman, Becka A. Alper, Besheer Mohamed, Chip Rotolo, Patricia Tevington, Justin Nortey, Asta Kallo, Jeff Diamant and Dalia Fahmy. 2025. Decline of Christianity in the U.S. has slowed, may have leveled off: Findings from the 2023–24 Religious Landscape Study. Report Pew Research Center Washington, D.C.: .
URL: *https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/2025/02/26/decline-of-christianity-in-the-us-has-slowed-may-have-leveled-off/*

Smith, Tom W. 1990. "Classifying Protestant Denominations." *Review of Religious Research* 31(3):225–245.

Soss, Joe. 1999. "Lessons of welfare: Policy design, political learning, and political action." *American Political Science Review* 93(2):363–380.

Stark, Rodney and William Sims Bainbridge. 1985. *The future of religion: Secularization, revival and cult formation*. Univ of California Press.

Steensland, Brian, Jerry Z. Park, Mark D. Regnerus, Lynn D. Robinson, W. Bradford Wilcox and Robert D. Woodberry. 2000. "The Measure of American Religion: Toward Improving the State of the Art." *Social Forces* 79(1):291–318.

Stolle, Dietlind and Thomas R. Rochon. 1998. "Are All Associations Alike? Member Diversity, Associational Type, and the Creation of Social Capital." *American Behavioral Scientist* 42(1):47–65.

Swierenga, Robert P. 2007. Ethnoreligious Political Behavior in the Mid-Nineteenth Century: Voting, Values, Cultures. In *Religion and American Politics: From the Colonial Period to the Present*, ed. Mark A. Noll and Luke E. Harlow. 2 ed. New York: Oxford University Press pp. 145–168.

Synan, Vinson. 1997. *The holiness-pentecostal tradition: Charismatic movements in the twentieth century*. 2 ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans.

Sønderskov, Kim Mannemar and Peter Thisted Dinesen. 2016. "Trusting the state, trusting each other? The effect of institutional trust on social trust." *Political behavior* 38(1):179–202.

Tiu, Andrew, Zachary Susswein, Alexes Merritt and Shweta Bansal. 2022. "Characterizing the spatiotemporal heterogeneity of the COVID-19 vaccination landscape." *American Journal of Epidemiology* 191(10):1792–1802.

Trejo, Guillermo. 2009. "Religious competition and ethnic mobilization in Latin America: Why the Catholic Church promotes indigenous movements in Mexico." *American Political Science Review* 103(3):323–342.

U.S. Census Bureau. 2026. "2010 decennial census and american community survey 5-year estimates.".
URL: *https://api.census.gov*

U.S. Census Bureau. N.d. "State and county QuickFacts.".
URL: *https://www.census.gov/quickfacts*

Uscinski, Joseph E., Adam M. Enders, Michelle I. Seelig, Casey A. Klofstad, John R. Funchion, Caleb Everett, Stefan Wuchty, Kamal Premaratne and Manohar N. Murthi. 2021. "American Politics in Two Dimensions: Partisan and Ideological Identities versus Anti-Establishment Orientations." *American Journal of Political Science* 65(4):877–895.

Van Erkel, Patrick FA and Tom WG Van Der Meer. 2016. "Macroeconomic performance, political

trust and the Great Recession: A multilevel analysis of the effects of within-country fluctuations in macroeconomic performance on political trust in 15 EU countries, 1999–2011." *European Journal of Political Research* 55(1):177–197.

Verba, S., K.L. Schlozman and H.E. Brady. 1995. *Voice and Equality: Civic Voluntarism in American Politics*. Harvard University Press.

Wald, Kenneth D. and Clyde Wilcox. 2006. "Getting religion: Has political science rediscovered the faith factor?" *American Political Science Review* 100(4):523–529.

Weber, Max. 1978. *Economy and Society: An Outline of Interpretive Sociology*. Economy and Society University of California Press. Issue: v. 1.

Whitehead, Andrew L. and Samuel L. Perry. 2020. *Taking America Back for God: Christian Nationalism in the United States*. Oxford University Press.

Woodberry, Robert D., Jerry Z. Park, Lyman A. Kellstedt, Mark D. Regnerus and Brian Steensland. 2012. "The measure of american religious traditions: Theoretical and measurement considerations." *Social Forces* 91(1):65–73.

Wuthnow, Robert. 1988. *The restructuring of american religion: Society and faith since world war II*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Zhang, Floyd Jiuyun. 2023. "Political endorsement by Nature and trust in scientific expertise during COVID-19." *Nature Human Behaviour* 7(5):696–706.

Zhu, Hongshen, Melanie Manion and Viola Rothschild. 2025. "Crisis and Correction: Do Government Rectification Efforts Restore Citizen Trust After Governance Failure?" *Political Behavior* 47(4):1595–1620.

Zmerli, Sonja and Ken Newton. 2008. "Social trust and attitudes toward democracy." *Public opinion quarterly* 72(4):706–724.

Supplementary Materials

Contents

Supplementary Materials **SI-1**

A Data and Measurement **SI-2**
A.1 The Denominational Institutionalization Index SI-2
A.2 Other Data Sources SI-3
A.3 Linking Respondents to DII SI-4

B Full Regression Tables **SI-5**
B.1 Validation: DII, Church Governance, and Religious Life SI-5
B.2 DII and Institutional Trust SI-7
B.3 DII and Populism SI-15

C Additional Analysis **SI-17**
C.1 Nativism and Racial Resentment SI-17
C.2 The Attendance Dose SI-17
C.3 Controlling for Individual-Level Theology SI-19
C.4 Subgroups by Theology and Politics SI-21

D Robustness Checks **SI-26**
D.1 Restricting to Waves That Ask for the Specific Denomination SI-26
D.2 Dropping the Nondenominational Cell SI-26

E Catholic Exceptionalism? **SI-28**

A Data and Measurement

A.1 The Denominational Institutionalization Index

Table SI-1: The coded ledger: 118 denominations and five residual categories

Denomination	A	B	C	D	DII	Denomination	A	B	C	D	DII
Christian Reformed Church	2	3	3	3	11	North American Baptist Conference	1	2	2	2	7
Episcopal Church in the USA	3	2	3	3	11	United Church of Christ	1	2	2	2	7
Reformed Presbyterian Church of North America	2	3	3	3	11	Allegheny Wesleyan Methodist Connection	2	2	1	1	6
Seventh-day Adventist	3	2	3	3	11	American Baptist Churches USA	1	2	2	1	6
United Methodist Church	3	2	3	3	11	Apostolic Christian	1	2	2	1	6
Associate Reformed Presbyterian	2	3	3	2	10	Church of the Brethren	2	0	2	2	6
Church of God (Cleveland TN)	3	2	2	3	10	Conservative Congregational Christian Conference	1	2	1	2	6
Church of the United Brethren in Christ	3	2	3	2	10	Convention of Original Free Will Baptists	1	2	1	2	6
Evangelical Lutheran Synod	1	3	3	3	10	Fellowship of Evangelical Bible Churches	1	2	1	2	6
Evangelical Presbyterian Church	2	2	3	3	10	Lutheran Congregations in Mission for Christ	1	2	1	2	6
Heritage Reformed Congregations	2	3	3	2	10	Primitive Methodist Church in the USA	2	2	1	1	6
Lutheran Church Missouri Synod	1	3	3	3	10	Seventh Day Baptist General Conference	1	2	1	2	6
Presbyterian Church in America	2	3	3	2	10	Sovereign Grace Churches	2	1	2	1	6
Presbyterian Church USA	2	2	3	3	10	United Pentecostal Church International	1	2	1	2	6
Protestant Reformed Churches in America	2	3	3	2	10	Assembly of Christian Churches	1	1	1	2	5
Reformed Church in America	2	3	2	3	10	Association of Free Lutheran Congregations	1	2	1	1	5
Reformed Church in the United States	2	3	3	2	10	Central Yearly Meeting of Friends	2	1	1	1	5
Salvation Army	3	3	2	2	10	Free Will Baptist	1	1	1	2	5
Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod	1	3	3	3	10	Friends United Meeting	2	1	1	1	5
African Methodist Episcopal	3	1	3	2	9	International Pentecostal Church of Christ	1	2	1	1	5
AME Zion	3	1	3	2	9	Pillar of Fire	3	1	1	0	5
Anglican Church (US respondents mostly ACNA/continuing)	3	2	2	2	9	Apostolic Lutheran Church in America	1	1	1	1	4
Bible Presbyterian Church	1	3	3	2	9	Charis Fellowship (Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches)	1	1	1	1	4
Christian and Missionary Alliance	3	2	2	2	9	Church of God of the Apostolic Faith	2	1	1	0	4
Christian Methodist Episcopal	3	1	3	2	9	Full Gospel Baptist Church Fellowship	1	1	1	1	4
Church of God in Christ	3	2	2	2	9	Vineyard USA	1	2	1	0	4
Church of God of Prophecy	3	2	2	2	9	Baptist Bible Fellowship International	0	2	1	0	3
Church of the Lutheran Confession	1	3	3	2	9	Baptist General Conference (Converge)	1	1	1	0	3
Evangelical Congregational Church	3	2	2	2	9	Baptist Missionary Association	1	1	1	0	3
Evangelical Lutheran Church in America	2	2	3	2	9	Calvary Chapel Association	1	1	1	0	3
Foursquare Gospel	3	2	2	2	9	Conservative Yearly Meetings of Friends	2	0	0	1	3
Free Methodist Church	3	2	2	2	9	General Association of Regular Baptists	1	1	1	0	3
Moravian Church in America	2	2	3	2	9	National Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Orthodox Presbyterian Church	2	2	3	2	9	National Baptist Convention of America	1	1	1	0	3
Pentecostal Holiness (IPHC)	3	2	2	2	9	National Missionary Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Worldwide Church of God (Grace Communion)	3	2	1	3	9	Progressive National Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Anglican Orthodox Church	3	2	2	1	8	Schwenkfelder Church	1	1	1	0	3
Assemblies of God	1	2	2	3	8	Southern Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Bible Fellowship Church	2	2	2	2	8	Advent Christian Church	0	1	1	0	2
Church of the Nazarene	2	2	2	2	8	American Baptist Association	0	1	1	0	2
Churches of God, General Conference	2	2	2	2	8	Church of God General Conference	0	1	1	0	2
Cumberland Presbyterian	2	2	2	2	8	Conservative Baptist Association	0	1	1	0	2
Evangelical Covenant Church	1	2	2	3	8	Friends General Conference	2	0	0	0	2
Evangelical Methodist Church	2	2	2	2	8	Independent Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Latvian Evangelical Lutheran Church in America	2	2	2	2	8	Independent Presbyterian	0	1	1	0	2
Open Bible Standard Churches	2	2	2	2	8	Independent Yearly Meetings of Friends	2	0	0	0	2
Pentecostal Church of God	2	2	2	2	8	Midwest Congregational Christian Fellowship	0	1	1	0	2
Reformed Mennonite Church	2	2	1	3	8	National Association of Congregational Christian Churches	1	0	1	0	2
The Missionary Church	2	2	2	2	8	Primitive Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Wesleyan Church	2	2	2	2	8	Reformed / Calvinist Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Apostolic Faith Mission of Portland OR	3	2	1	1	7	Christian Churches and Churches of Christ	0	0	1	0	1
Brethren in Christ Church	2	2	2	1	7	Congregational Christian Churches, Additional	0	0	1	0	1
Church of God (Anderson IN)	1	2	2	2	7	Cooperative Baptist Fellowship	0	0	1	0	1
Church of the Lutheran Brethren of America	1	2	2	2	7	Independent Congregational Church	0	0	1	0	1
Congregational Holiness Church	2	2	1	2	7	Plymouth Brethren (Christian/Open Brethren)	0	1	0	0	1
Congregational Methodist Church	1	2	2	2	7	Church of Christ	0	0	0	0	0
Disciples of Christ	1	2	2	2	7	*Residual categories*					
Evangelical Free Church of America	1	2	2	2	7	Community church	0	0	0	0	0
Evangelical Friends Church International	2	2	1	2	7	Interdenominational	0	0	0	0	0
Fellowship of Evangelical Churches	1	2	2	2	7	Nondenominational charismatic	0	0	0	0	0
Independent Methodist	1	2	2	2	7	Nondenominational evangelical	0	0	0	0	0
Mennonite Church USA	1	1	2	3	7	Nondenominational fundamentalist	0	0	0	0	0

Notes. A = polity, B = confessional subscription, C = ordination threshold, D = disciplinary machinery, each 0–3. DII is the unweighted sum. Bodies are sorted by DII and read down the left column, then the right. The residual categories are response options the survey instruments carry and enter the index at zero. Sources and the justification for every coding decision are released with the dataset.

A.2 Other Data Sources

Table SI-2: Data sources

Source	Years	Use
Individual-level surveys		
General Social Survey	1972–2022	Trust, behaviour, IV
ANES cumulative file	1972–2024	Trust, populism
ANES time series	2016, 2020, 2024	Wave denomination codes. Trust, populism
Cooperative Election Study	2016, 2022	Local government, federal trust, nativism, racial resentment
Pew Religious Landscape Study	2007, 2014	Detailed codes. Religious behaviour
Validation sources		
National Congregations Study	1998–2019	Denomination reported by the congregation's informant
Cooperative Clergy Study Project	2000, 2017	Pastors sampled by denomination
County-level sources (Table 7)		
U.S. Religion Census (Grammich, 2012)	2010	County DII, the adherent-weighted mean of 85 reporting bodies; Protestant and Catholic adherence rates
County primary returns (Hamner, 2016)	2016	Trump share of the Republican presidential primary vote, 39 states
Bansal Lab vaccination series (Tiu et al., 2022)	2021	Share of residents fully vaccinated, last report on or before December 31, 2021
U.S. Census Bureau (U.S. Census Bureau, 2026, N.d.)	2006–2016	Shares white, Hispanic, foreign born, without a four-year degree, rural, aged 65 and over, unemployed, and below the poverty line; log median household income; log population density; nine European-ancestry shares
MIT Election Data and Science Lab (MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2018)	2012	Romney share of the general-election vote
Frontier experience (Bazzi, Fiszbein and Gebresilasse, 2020)	1790–1890	Decades the county lay within 100 km of the frontier line
County presidential returns (McGovern, 2024)	2020	Trump share of the general-election vote

A.3 Linking Respondents to DII

Each survey asks its own denomination question, and each needs to be mapped to the DII dataset through a survey-specific crosswalk. I take two steps. First, when a respondent either selects a denomination from the survey-provided list or names one in the open text, I assign the DII score of that specific denomination.

However, not all Protestant respondents can be linked directly to a denomination. Earlier waves of the GSS and ANES asked respondents only to select a Protestant family (Baptist, Presbyterian, Methodist, Pentecostal, etc.), not the specific denomination. Even when a list of denominations is provided, some respondents stop at the family level or, as in the CES, choose "other" within a family. In these cases I assign the respondent to the family's largest body, with race taken into account where a family bundles historically white and historically Black bodies. A Baptist without a named convention scores as the Southern Baptist Convention, a Methodist as the United Methodist Church, a Lutheran as the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, and a Presbyterian as the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.). A Black respondent goes instead to the largest body of the family's Black wing, the National Baptist Convention for Baptists and the African Methodist Episcopal Church for Methodists.

This practice provides a reasonable proxy, as most variation in the DII lies within families rather than between them. The fallback carries 39.4 percent of coded GSS respondents and 38.3 percent of the ANES cumulative file, and roughly 15 percent in the recent ANES waves, the RLS, and the CES (Table SI-3). In Appendix D.1, I rerun the main analysis on the waves in which the GSS and ANES ask for the specific denomination, 1984 and later in the GSS and 1990 and later in the ANES, and the results are essentially the same.

Table SI-3: Respondents assigned by family rule

	Assigned by family rule
General Social Survey, 1972–2022	39.4%
ANES cumulative file, 1972–2024	38.3%
ANES time series, 2016–2024	16.0%
Cooperative Election Study, 2016	13.5%
Cooperative Election Study, 2022	13.7%
Pew Religious Landscape Study, 2007	15.0%
Pew Religious Landscape Study, 2014	15.3%

B Full Regression Tables

B.1 Validation: DII, Church Governance, and Religious Life

Tables SI-4 to SI-6 report the full regression tables behind Tables 2 and 3.

Table SI-4: Validation of the dimension scores: full specifications

	A	B		C			DII	
	Denom. rep. hosted (1)	Agrees *Jesus returns* (2)	SD of agreement (denom.) (3)	Seminary grad. (inform.) (4)	Seminary grad. (self) (5)	Leader from inside (6)	Written budget (7)	Board met (8)
Institutionalization score (raw)	0.1324***	0.2026*	−0.2055*	0.0843***	0.1606**	−0.0727***	0.0125**	0.0095***
	(0.0290)	(0.0927)	(0.0959)	(0.0071)	(0.0475)	(0.0123)	(0.0033)	(0.0023)
Log adult size / members	0.0222†	−0.1198***	—	0.0573***	0.0821*	−0.0038	0.0612***	0.0295†
	(0.0124)	(0.0249)		(0.0086)	(0.0264)	(0.0088)	(0.0091)	(0.0153)
White share of congregation	−0.0010	—	—	0.0004	—	−0.0014***	0.0010***	0.0003
	(0.0006)			(0.0004)		(0.0003)	(0.0002)	(0.0003)
Congregation age (years)	0.0006*	—	—	0.0008*	—	−0.0003	0.0002*	−0.0002
	(0.0002)			(0.0004)		(0.0003)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)
Urban location	—	−0.1191**	—	—	0.0678*	—	—	—
		(0.0377)			(0.0267)			
Clergy female	—	−0.4835**	—	—	0.0441	—	—	—
		(0.1216)			(0.0278)			
Clergy age (years)	—	−0.0095***	—	—	−0.0025**	—	—	—
		(0.0019)			(0.0007)			
Fixed effects	Div.+year	Year	None	Div.+year	State+year	Div.+year	Div.+year	Div.+year
Observations	2,505	6,652	17	1,237	2,366	1,241	2,494	626
Denominations (clusters)	17	17	17	17	10	17	17	17
DV mean	0.532	4.501	0.716	0.808	0.848	0.187	0.897	0.941
DV SD	0.499	0.897	0.351	0.394	0.359	0.390	0.305	0.236
Data source	NCS	CCSP 2000	CCSP 2000	NCS	CCSP 2017	NCS	NCS	NCS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. The regressor is the raw score of the dimension named in the column group, A, B, or C on 0–3, or the full DII on 0–12. NCS models (columns 1, 4, 6, 7, 8) are estimated on congregations with division and survey-year fixed effects. CCSP models (columns 2, 5) are estimated on individual clergy, column 2 on the 2000 wave and column 5 on the 2017 wave with state fixed effects. Column 2 is agreement that Jesus will return to earth on a 5-point scale, higher = more agreement. Column 3 has one observation per denomination, the standard deviation of that agreement among its clergy, with an ordinary standard error. Elsewhere standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-5: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior I: private devotion

	Reads scripture		Prays more often		Born-again		Rel. exp. changed life
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	−0.0313**	−0.0413***	−0.0136**	−0.0278***	−0.0215***	−0.0253***	−0.0081*
	(0.0099)	(0.0059)	(0.0043)	(0.0041)	(0.0057)	(0.0042)	(0.0040)
Attendance	0.2271***	0.3919***	0.1539***	0.2221***	0.0475***	0.0720***	0.0389***
	(0.0245)	(0.0090)	(0.0067)	(0.0106)	(0.0030)	(0.0041)	(0.0041)
Strength of affiliation	0.4168***	—	0.3340***	—	0.0804***	—	0.0844***
	(0.0413)		(0.0274)		(0.0099)		(0.0158)
Importance of religion	—	0.7219***	—	1.0829***	—	0.1729***	—
		(0.0151)		(0.0361)		(0.0116)	
Ideology	0.1021***	−0.1020***	0.0420**	−0.0766***	0.0228***	−0.0597***	0.0265***
	(0.0215)	(0.0117)	(0.0136)	(0.0150)	(0.0047)	(0.0078)	(0.0051)
Party identification	0.0008	0.0170	0.0083	0.0206*	0.0042†	−0.0129**	−0.0049
	(0.0197)	(0.0120)	(0.0064)	(0.0084)	(0.0023)	(0.0040)	(0.0044)
Education	−0.0603	−0.0066	−0.0464***	−0.0000	−0.0372***	−0.0486***	−0.0117
	(0.0386)	(0.0123)	(0.0121)	(0.0094)	(0.0095)	(0.0078)	(0.0102)
Age	0.0061*	0.0135***	0.0079***	0.0050†	−0.0006	0.0018	−0.0015†
	(0.0028)	(0.0031)	(0.0009)	(0.0026)	(0.0005)	(0.0014)	(0.0008)
Female	0.2594**	0.1493***	0.5075***	0.3688***	0.0168*	−0.0056	0.0313*
	(0.0852)	(0.0227)	(0.0376)	(0.0327)	(0.0071)	(0.0054)	(0.0119)
Black	0.3398*	0.1794***	0.3372***	0.0660*	0.0613†	0.0176	0.0408
	(0.1550)	(0.0393)	(0.0331)	(0.0266)	(0.0360)	(0.0358)	(0.0355)
Other race	0.1584	0.1666***	0.1002	0.0794*	0.0240	0.0465*	−0.0905*
	(0.2827)	(0.0388)	(0.0611)	(0.0338)	(0.0230)	(0.0221)	(0.0412)
Hispanic	—	0.1519**	0.1930**	0.0787	0.0937**	0.0789***	0.1972***
		(0.0463)	(0.0593)	(0.0488)	(0.0293)	(0.0207)	(0.0296)
Fixed effects	Div. + year	State + wave	Div. + year	State + wave	Div. + year	State + wave	Div. + year
Observations	1,299	28,129	16,664	28,079	10,221	27,594	4,343
Denominations (clusters)	39	96	50	96	49	96	46
DV mean	2.765	3.753	4.644	5.871	0.591	0.617	0.504
DV SD	1.546	1.507	1.417	1.554	0.492	0.486	0.500
Data source	GSS (1988, 1998)	RLS 2007+14	GSS (1983–2022)	RLS 2007+14	GSS (1988–2022)	RLS 2007+14	GSS (1998–2010)

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Outcomes are on their native scales. Scripture reading 6-point (GSS) or 5-point (RLS), prayer 6-point (GSS) or 7-point (RLS), born-again and life-changing experience 0/1. All models control for attendance, strength of affiliation (RLS asks about importance of religion), ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, and Hispanic origin, with division and survey-year fixed effects (GSS) or state and wave fixed effects (RLS). The GSS asked scripture reading only in 1988 and 1998 and the life-changing experience item only in 1998, 2004–2010, and 2021. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-6: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior II: congregational participation

	Official member	Volunteers through church	Church-affiliated group member	Social activities at church	Choir or musical program	Works with children/ youth	Church activ. beyond services
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0080***	0.0190***	0.0042**	0.0063*	0.0044	−0.0024	0.0055
	(0.0020)	(0.0033)	(0.0014)	(0.0028)	(0.0046)	(0.0039)	(0.0056)
Attendance	0.1373***	0.5390***	0.0967***	0.6167***	0.4411***	0.4784***	0.5706***
	(0.0052)	(0.0120)	(0.0018)	(0.0141)	(0.0181)	(0.0202)	(0.0114)
Strength of affiliation	—	—	0.0728***	—	—	—	0.3101***
			(0.0053)				(0.0221)
Importance of religion	0.0891***	0.2008***	—	0.2088***	0.0950***	0.1250***	—
	(0.0089)	(0.0246)		(0.0289)	(0.0245)	(0.0299)	
Ideology	0.0056*	−0.0208†	0.0055†	−0.0066	−0.0048	−0.0291*	−0.0246
	(0.0027)	(0.0124)	(0.0028)	(0.0129)	(0.0111)	(0.0134)	(0.0203)
Party identification	−0.0151***	0.0221	0.0035*	−0.0141	0.0256*	0.0001	0.0188*
	(0.0030)	(0.0150)	(0.0015)	(0.0126)	(0.0127)	(0.0114)	(0.0092)
Education	0.0184***	0.0669***	0.0381***	0.0480***	0.0168	0.0566***	0.1295***
	(0.0024)	(0.0135)	(0.0050)	(0.0089)	(0.0165)	(0.0116)	(0.0259)
Age	0.0045***	−0.0072	0.0018***	−0.0066*	−0.0241***	−0.1156***	−0.0008
	(0.0011)	(0.0045)	(0.0002)	(0.0032)	(0.0042)	(0.0066)	(0.0012)
Female	−0.0090†	−0.0677**	0.0287**	−0.0254	−0.0493**	0.0226	0.0535
	(0.0048)	(0.0200)	(0.0086)	(0.0181)	(0.0181)	(0.0217)	(0.0355)
Black	0.0537***	0.1738***	0.0323**	0.1306***	0.5073***	0.3210***	0.0814
	(0.0134)	(0.0377)	(0.0114)	(0.0252)	(0.0240)	(0.0468)	(0.0718)
Other race	−0.0002	0.1145**	−0.0448	0.0634	0.1304*	0.1349*	0.0649
	(0.0128)	(0.0384)	(0.0412)	(0.0563)	(0.0633)	(0.0532)	(0.1037)
Hispanic	0.0060	0.1665*	—	0.0186	0.1548	0.1292†	−0.1327
	(0.0134)	(0.0668)		(0.0683)	(0.0970)	(0.0745)	(0.1090)
Fixed effects	State + wave	State	Div. + year	State	State	State	Div. + year
Observations	28,221	12,821	9,928	12,845	12,850	12,858	8,885
Denominations (clusters)	96	93	48	93	93	93	49
DV mean	0.736	2.660	0.420	3.228	1.915	2.391	3.641
DV SD	0.441	1.365	0.494	1.300	1.499	1.532	2.505
Data source	RLS 2007+14	RLS 2007	GSS (1974–1994)	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	GSS (1991–2022)

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, specifications as in Table SI-5. Outcomes are on their native scales. Official membership is 0/1 in both RLS waves. The four church-activity items are the 2007 battery, 5-point frequency scales asked of respondents attending at least a few times a year. Church-affiliated group membership is the GSS voluntary-associations item, 0/1. Church activities beyond services is the GSS 11-point frequency item. The Hispanic indicator cannot be estimated for church-affiliated group membership (column 3), as the item was asked in 1974 to 1994, before the GSS asked Hispanic origin. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

B.2 DII and Institutional Trust

Tables SI-7 to SI-10 report full regression tables summarized in Table 4. Tables SI-11 to SI-13 report the OLS and instrumental-variables models of Table 5.

Table SI-7: Denominational institutionalization and confidence in institutions (GSS)

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)				
	Supreme Court (1)	Executive branch (2)	Congress (3)	Press (4)	Television (5)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0109***	0.0031*	0.0003	0.0062***	0.0053**
	(0.0020)	(0.0012)	(0.0009)	(0.0011)	(0.0018)
Attendance	−0.0013	0.0153***	0.0155***	−0.0054**	−0.0215***
	(0.0027)	(0.0023)	(0.0019)	(0.0016)	(0.0022)
Ideology	−0.0147***	−0.0175**	−0.0105*	−0.0498***	−0.0288***
	(0.0032)	(0.0053)	(0.0039)	(0.0084)	(0.0069)
Party identification	0.0092**	0.0092†	−0.0097***	−0.0340***	−0.0130***
	(0.0030)	(0.0046)	(0.0026)	(0.0034)	(0.0016)
Education	0.0614***	0.0320***	0.0016	0.0033	−0.0333***
	(0.0075)	(0.0059)	(0.0066)	(0.0051)	(0.0064)
Age	−0.0011*	−0.0001	−0.0020***	−0.0001	0.0002
	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)
Female	−0.0369***	−0.0063	0.0276*	−0.0080	−0.0186*
	(0.0101)	(0.0106)	(0.0135)	(0.0089)	(0.0084)
Log family income	0.0080	−0.0062	−0.0208***	−0.0297***	−0.0402***
	(0.0083)	(0.0061)	(0.0050)	(0.0055)	(0.0049)
Black	−0.0332†	0.0120	0.0161	0.0192	0.1180***
	(0.0196)	(0.0143)	(0.0128)	(0.0158)	(0.0152)
Other race	0.0821***	0.1173**	0.1502***	0.1462***	0.0876***
	(0.0196)	(0.0428)	(0.0294)	(0.0402)	(0.0224)
Hispanic	0.0063	0.1160**	0.1028**	−0.0175	−0.0486†
	(0.0283)	(0.0377)	(0.0343)	(0.0213)	(0.0276)
Observations	20,074	20,335	20,334	20,434	20,454
Denominations (clusters)	52	52	52	52	52
DV mean	2.149	1.819	1.775	1.798	1.782
DV SD	0.670	0.682	0.629	0.675	0.649

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)			
	Education (6)	Scientific community (7)	Medicine (8)	Organized religion (9)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0051**	0.0078**	0.0068***	0.0095**
	(0.0019)	(0.0025)	(0.0011)	(0.0033)
Attendance	0.0119***	−0.0117**	0.0052*	0.0514***
	(0.0031)	(0.0040)	(0.0025)	(0.0047)
Ideology	−0.0259***	−0.0182**	−0.0059	0.0032
	(0.0068)	(0.0054)	(0.0052)	(0.0050)
Party identification	−0.0122**	−0.0039	0.0013	0.0134***
	(0.0039)	(0.0029)	(0.0029)	(0.0030)
Education	0.0048	0.0863***	0.0299***	0.0003
	(0.0057)	(0.0046)	(0.0057)	(0.0059)
Age	0.0007*	−0.0005*	−0.0020***	0.0008*
	(0.0003)	(0.0002)	(0.0005)	(0.0004)
Female	0.0015	−0.0662***	−0.0456***	−0.0118
	(0.0129)	(0.0074)	(0.0091)	(0.0133)
Log family income	−0.0322***	0.0333***	0.0089†	−0.0138*
	(0.0052)	(0.0051)	(0.0051)	(0.0056)
Black	0.1018***	−0.1531***	−0.0236	0.0433†
	(0.0233)	(0.0191)	(0.0153)	(0.0230)
Other race	0.1012**	−0.0166	−0.0276	0.0208
	(0.0359)	(0.0164)	(0.0197)	(0.0445)
Hispanic	0.0612*	0.0278	−0.0705**	−0.0545*
	(0.0300)	(0.0401)	(0.0202)	(0.0206)
Observations	20,450	19,468	20,508	20,161
Denominations (clusters)	52	52	52	52
DV mean	2.156	2.319	2.377	2.128
DV SD	0.647	0.616	0.632	0.665

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, GSS 1973–2022. The outcomes are the GSS confidence items of Table 4 on their native 3-point scale, higher = more confidence. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log real family income, race, and Hispanic origin, with division and survey-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-8: Affect toward institutions and trust in government, ANES cumulative file (full coefficients)

	Thermometers (0–97)			Trust in government			
	Supreme Court (1)	Federal govt (2)	Con-gress (3)	Hardly any crooked (4)	Benefit of all (5)	Trust govt do right (6)	Does not waste (7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.1468***	0.1647*	0.0305	0.0072***	0.0039***	0.0053*	0.0047***
	(0.0294)	(0.0794)	(0.0716)	(0.0016)	(0.0008)	(0.0023)	(0.0008)
Attendance	−0.0776	0.6144**	0.5120**	−0.0020	0.0074**	0.0053	0.0148***
	(0.1260)	(0.2257)	(0.1608)	(0.0051)	(0.0026)	(0.0043)	(0.0027)
Ideology	0.6856***	−1.2998***	0.0239	−0.0108†	−0.0018	−0.0121**	−0.0354***
	(0.1741)	(0.2776)	(0.1703)	(0.0063)	(0.0034)	(0.0037)	(0.0047)
Party identification	0.4224**	−0.9072***	−0.3163**	0.0022	0.0109***	−0.0011	−0.0115***
	(0.1412)	(0.1955)	(0.1073)	(0.0036)	(0.0030)	(0.0032)	(0.0021)
Education	0.2455	−0.8968†	−1.7165***	0.0589***	0.0089	0.0128†	0.0090
	(0.2600)	(0.4723)	(0.3413)	(0.0087)	(0.0058)	(0.0065)	(0.0089)
Age	0.1261***	0.0589***	0.0111	0.0021***	−0.0005**	−0.0002	−0.0022***
	(0.0095)	(0.0137)	(0.0143)	(0.0003)	(0.0002)	(0.0003)	(0.0002)
Female	0.7510*	1.2574	3.5837***	−0.0689***	0.0065	−0.0150	0.0301***
	(0.3187)	(0.8374)	(0.5054)	(0.0113)	(0.0047)	(0.0115)	(0.0085)
Family-income group	0.0399	−1.0759***	−1.3031***	0.0081†	−0.0021	−0.0102*	−0.0174***
	(0.1730)	(0.2210)	(0.1781)	(0.0046)	(0.0039)	(0.0040)	(0.0034)
Black	4.2867***	11.2386***	6.9122***	−0.0296	0.0329**	−0.0675***	0.0620***
	(0.6377)	(1.0097)	(0.4927)	(0.0251)	(0.0111)	(0.0165)	(0.0128)
Other race	0.5387	5.0731***	2.9346**	−0.0821**	0.0292†	0.0302	0.0191
	(0.9522)	(0.8010)	(1.0456)	(0.0302)	(0.0162)	(0.0604)	(0.0295)
Hispanic	2.1580	8.7197***	6.2510***	0.1295***	0.0682*	0.0561*	0.0501*
	(1.4809)	(1.2984)	(1.6198)	(0.0240)	(0.0287)	(0.0219)	(0.0192)
Observations	9,257	5,826	9,862	11,509	15,695	11,248	16,287
Denominations (clusters)	67	61	68	63	67	61	68
Years	1980–2024	1980–2012	1980–2024	1972–2012	1972–2024	1972–2012	1972–2024
DV mean	60.88	48.49	48.43	1.61	0.25	2.37	1.30
DV SD	19.74	22.58	21.68	0.64	0.43	0.56	0.49

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, ANES cumulative file, 1972–2024. The outcomes are the feeling thermometers of Table 4 (columns 1–3, 0–97) and the trust-in-government items of panel A of Table 6 (columns 4–7) on their native scales, higher = warmer or more trusting. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, family-income group, race, and Hispanic origin, with state and survey-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-9: Trust in intermediary institutions, ANES 2024 (full coefficients)

	ANES 2024 scientists (1)	ANES 2024 judiciary (2)	ANES 2024 Congress (3)	ANES 2024 government (4)	ANES 2024 parties (5)	ANES 2024 trad. media (6)	Colleges & universities 2024 (7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0051	0.0067	0.0040	0.0074*	0.0082*	0.0156***	0.0227**
	(0.0041)	(0.0048)	(0.0040)	(0.0029)	(0.0034)	(0.0041)	(0.0081)
Attendance	−0.0254***	0.0063	0.0088	0.0136	0.0202*	0.0105	0.0176
	(0.0062)	(0.0063)	(0.0056)	(0.0085)	(0.0082)	(0.0090)	(0.0236)
Ideology	−0.1126***	0.0089	−0.0393*	−0.0656***	−0.0056	−0.0968***	−0.2761***
	(0.0163)	(0.0137)	(0.0157)	(0.0150)	(0.0142)	(0.0172)	(0.0306)
Party identification	−0.0905***	0.0279**	0.0324**	−0.0107	0.0114	−0.1133***	−0.0542†
	(0.0108)	(0.0093)	(0.0104)	(0.0101)	(0.0101)	(0.0121)	(0.0319)
Education	0.0924***	0.0469**	0.0017	0.0436***	−0.0466***	0.0062	0.0037
	(0.0237)	(0.0151)	(0.0144)	(0.0115)	(0.0126)	(0.0129)	(0.0602)
Age	0.0026**	0.0060***	0.0049***	0.0103***	0.0062***	0.0039***	−0.0077***
	(0.0008)	(0.0017)	(0.0007)	(0.0008)	(0.0009)	(0.0008)	(0.0021)
Female	−0.0093	−0.0036	0.1306***	0.0162	0.1197***	0.0565	0.2461*
	(0.0231)	(0.0305)	(0.0354)	(0.0235)	(0.0251)	(0.0448)	(0.1142)
Family-income group	0.0500**	0.0397**	0.0134	0.0187	−0.0193†	0.0156*	−0.0419
	(0.0184)	(0.0141)	(0.0116)	(0.0181)	(0.0102)	(0.0073)	(0.0307)
Black	−0.2900***	−0.0643†	0.0743	0.0592	0.1128**	−0.0740	0.2532
	(0.0750)	(0.0380)	(0.0465)	(0.0489)	(0.0343)	(0.0875)	(0.2488)
Other race	−0.1130*	0.0241	0.0812	0.1524*	0.2729***	0.0335	−0.0147
	(0.0542)	(0.0636)	(0.0575)	(0.0603)	(0.0552)	(0.0453)	(0.1295)
Hispanic	0.0674	−0.1262	0.5066***	0.3537	0.3861†	0.3702*	0.2307
	(0.3548)	(0.4194)	(0.1000)	(0.3425)	(0.2066)	(0.1479)	(0.2537)
Observations	1,605	1,603	1,606	1,603	1,602	1,605	1,763
Denominations (clusters)	43	43	43	43	43	43	44
DV mean	3.05	2.70	2.36	2.37	2.22	2.25	3.14
DV SD	0.80	0.72	0.71	0.74	0.72	0.88	1.70

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, ANES 2024. The outcomes are the trust items of Table 4 (columns 1–6) on their native 4-point scale, higher = more trust, and approval of how colleges and universities are run (column 7) on its native 7-point scale, higher = more approval. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, family-income quintile, race, and Hispanic origin, with state fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-10: The CES cells of the institution matrix (full coefficients)

	Outcomes standardized (SD units)			
	Local schools	Mayor / city mgr.	City council	Trust federal govt (2022)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0079**	0.0059***	0.0043*	0.0118**
	(0.0028)	(0.0016)	(0.0019)	(0.0037)
Attendance	0.0302***	0.0414***	0.0505***	0.0348***
	(0.0048)	(0.0073)	(0.0092)	(0.0056)
Ideology	-0.0282***	-0.0490***	-0.0383**	-0.1870***
	(0.0074)	(0.0112)	(0.0116)	(0.0142)
Party identification	-0.0039	-0.0022	-0.0016	-0.1490***
	(0.0052)	(0.0066)	(0.0056)	(0.0096)
Education	0.0047	0.0099	0.0027	-0.0073
	(0.0059)	(0.0068)	(0.0060)	(0.0078)
Age	0.0019*	0.0014†	-0.0008	-0.0007
	(0.0008)	(0.0009)	(0.0008)	(0.0009)
Female	-0.0227	0.0290	0.0701***	0.0394†
	(0.0228)	(0.0215)	(0.0170)	(0.0209)
Family income (z)	0.1002***	0.0692***	0.0627***	-0.0247*
	(0.0093)	(0.0142)	(0.0137)	(0.0119)
Black	-0.2568***	-0.0522†	-0.0756*	0.1493***
	(0.0199)	(0.0266)	(0.0336)	(0.0302)
Other race	-0.1782***	-0.1282***	-0.0890*	-0.1957***
	(0.0404)	(0.0356)	(0.0440)	(0.0322)
Hispanic	-0.0639	0.0102	-0.0555	0.0545
	(0.0407)	(0.0334)	(0.0441)	(0.0388)
Observations	15,330	14,146	14,265	13,212
Denominations (clusters)	57	57	57	57

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, CES 2016 (columns 1–4) and CES 2022 (column 5). The outcomes are the CES items of Table 4, the 2016 local report-card grades (A to F, reversed so higher = better) and the 2022 trust-in-federal-government item (0–3, higher = more trust), standardized. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, standardized family income, race, and Hispanic origin, with state fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-11: OLS on the common complete-case sample (full coefficients, panel A)

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)				
	Executive branch (1)	Congress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0045***	0.0024†	0.0108***	0.0097**	0.0084***
	(0.0013)	(0.0012)	(0.0022)	(0.0033)	(0.0022)
Attendance	0.0172***	0.0169***	−0.0006	0.0505***	−0.0114**
	(0.0031)	(0.0029)	(0.0028)	(0.0052)	(0.0036)
Ideology	−0.0090	−0.0120*	−0.0111*	0.0098*	−0.0178**
	(0.0074)	(0.0050)	(0.0042)	(0.0048)	(0.0059)
Party identification	0.0176***	−0.0138***	0.0142***	0.0151***	−0.0046
	(0.0045)	(0.0028)	(0.0040)	(0.0032)	(0.0033)
Education	0.0303***	−0.0050	0.0557***	0.0075	0.0839***
	(0.0065)	(0.0080)	(0.0080)	(0.0075)	(0.0067)
Age	−0.0002	−0.0021***	−0.0012*	0.0008	−0.0003
	(0.0004)	(0.0005)	(0.0005)	(0.0006)	(0.0003)
Female	−0.0100	0.0324**	−0.0187†	−0.0113	−0.0552***
	(0.0117)	(0.0117)	(0.0109)	(0.0155)	(0.0110)
Log family income	−0.0044	−0.0213***	0.0052	−0.0098	0.0332***
	(0.0056)	(0.0052)	(0.0107)	(0.0074)	(0.0058)
Black	0.0011	−0.0141	−0.0505†	0.0415†	−0.1563***
	(0.0207)	(0.0175)	(0.0294)	(0.0236)	(0.0209)
Other race	0.0289	0.0899**	0.0851†	−0.0367	−0.0467
	(0.0899)	(0.0312)	(0.0431)	(0.0559)	(0.0292)
Hispanic	0.1323†	0.1628*	0.0546	0.0147	0.0432
	(0.0776)	(0.0634)	(0.0798)	(0.0636)	(0.0679)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342
Denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)			
	Medicine (6)	Education (7)	Press (8)	Television (9)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0070***	0.0063**	0.0056***	0.0050**
	(0.0009)	(0.0022)	(0.0014)	(0.0017)
Attendance	0.0058*	0.0122***	−0.0057**	−0.0213***
	(0.0027)	(0.0024)	(0.0021)	(0.0030)
Ideology	−0.0078	−0.0258***	−0.0567***	−0.0245**
	(0.0073)	(0.0074)	(0.0097)	(0.0080)
Party identification	0.0019	−0.0100*	−0.0400***	−0.0133***
	(0.0037)	(0.0049)	(0.0032)	(0.0022)
Education	0.0239**	0.0043	0.0021	−0.0276***
	(0.0070)	(0.0049)	(0.0058)	(0.0073)
Age	−0.0019***	0.0010*	0.0001	0.0005
	(0.0005)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0005)
Female	−0.0271*	−0.0028	−0.0015	−0.0044
	(0.0103)	(0.0157)	(0.0083)	(0.0111)
Log family income	0.0137*	−0.0216**	−0.0212***	−0.0324***
	(0.0062)	(0.0066)	(0.0058)	(0.0056)
Black	−0.0488*	0.0618*	−0.0006	0.0931***
	(0.0184)	(0.0247)	(0.0260)	(0.0186)
Other race	−0.0743†	0.0899*	0.0652	0.0765
	(0.0430)	(0.0340)	(0.0855)	(0.0481)
Hispanic	−0.0607	0.1296**	0.0969	0.0118
	(0.0618)	(0.0463)	(0.0645)	(0.0490)
Observations	11,872	11,856	11,837	11,839
Denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants raised Protestant, GSS 1973–2022. The outcomes are the GSS confidence items of Table 5 on their native 3-point scale, higher = more confidence. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log real family income, race, and Hispanic origin, with division and survey-year fixed effects. All three panels use the same sample, the respondents with complete childhood-background data. Standard errors are clustered on the adult denomination.

Table SI-12: Childhood-DII 2SLS, baseline specification (full coefficients, panel B)

	Confidence in... (1–3, higher = more confidence)				
	Executive branch (1)	Congress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)
DII (instrumented)	0.0035†	−0.0012	0.0111***	0.0092**	0.0085**
	(0.0017)	(0.0023)	(0.0029)	(0.0032)	(0.0027)
Attendance	0.0171***	0.0166***	−0.0006	0.0504***	−0.0114*
	(0.0036)	(0.0028)	(0.0036)	(0.0045)	(0.0044)
Ideology	−0.0092†	−0.0127**	−0.0111**	0.0097†	−0.0177***
	(0.0053)	(0.0044)	(0.0041)	(0.0049)	(0.0045)
Party identification	0.0176***	−0.0135***	0.0142***	0.0152***	−0.0046
	(0.0034)	(0.0033)	(0.0035)	(0.0041)	(0.0030)
Education	0.0308***	−0.0032	0.0555***	0.0077	0.0838***
	(0.0060)	(0.0059)	(0.0095)	(0.0059)	(0.0061)
Age	−0.0002	−0.0020***	−0.0012**	0.0008	−0.0003
	(0.0004)	(0.0004)	(0.0004)	(0.0005)	(0.0004)
Female	−0.0098	0.0330*	−0.0187	−0.0113	−0.0552***
	(0.0165)	(0.0154)	(0.0125)	(0.0151)	(0.0146)
Log family income	−0.0042	−0.0207***	0.0052	−0.0098	0.0332***
	(0.0075)	(0.0056)	(0.0092)	(0.0080)	(0.0031)
Black	−0.0007	−0.0205	−0.0500**	0.0408*	−0.1561***
	(0.0147)	(0.0164)	(0.0181)	(0.0188)	(0.0180)
Other race	0.0282	0.0878*	0.0853**	−0.0370	−0.0466
	(0.0828)	(0.0369)	(0.0299)	(0.0672)	(0.0528)
Hispanic	0.1327	0.1639***	0.0545	0.0148	0.0432
	(0.0858)	(0.0241)	(0.0706)	(0.0565)	(0.0572)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1175	1142	1123	1118	1109

	Confidence in... (1–3, higher = more confidence)			
	Medicine (6)	Education (7)	Press (8)	Television (9)
DII (instrumented)	0.0100***	0.0034†	0.0042	0.0051*
	(0.0019)	(0.0019)	(0.0027)	(0.0025)
Attendance	0.0061*	0.0119***	−0.0058*	−0.0213***
	(0.0025)	(0.0021)	(0.0024)	(0.0031)
Ideology	−0.0071	−0.0264**	−0.0570***	−0.0245**
	(0.0051)	(0.0079)	(0.0081)	(0.0072)
Party identification	0.0016	−0.0098***	−0.0399***	−0.0133***
	(0.0030)	(0.0027)	(0.0036)	(0.0024)
Education	0.0223*	0.0058	0.0028	−0.0277**
	(0.0088)	(0.0048)	(0.0068)	(0.0094)
Age	−0.0020***	0.0011*	0.0001	0.0005
	(0.0005)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0004)
Female	−0.0276**	−0.0023	−0.0013	−0.0044
	(0.0094)	(0.0148)	(0.0088)	(0.0130)
Log family income	0.0132	−0.0211*	−0.0210**	−0.0324***
	(0.0091)	(0.0082)	(0.0072)	(0.0080)
Black	−0.0433**	0.0565***	−0.0030	0.0932***
	(0.0137)	(0.0136)	(0.0227)	(0.0141)
Other race	−0.0724†	0.0880†	0.0644	0.0766
	(0.0370)	(0.0440)	(0.0959)	(0.0541)
Hispanic	−0.0617	0.1305**	0.0974	0.0118
	(0.0696)	(0.0380)	(0.0590)	(0.0570)
Observations	11,872	11,856	11,837	11,839
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1137	1157	1193	1162

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Two-stage least squares, instrumenting the DII with the DII of the denomination in which the respondent was raised at age 16. Sample, outcomes, and controls as in panel A. Standard errors are clustered on the childhood denomination.

Table SI-13: Childhood-DII 2SLS with the full childhood-background battery (full coefficients, panel C), columns (1) to (5)

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)				
	Executive branch (1)	Congress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)
DII (instrumented)	0.0025	−0.0008	0.0097***	0.0091*	0.0058*
	(0.0019)	(0.0025)	(0.0027)	(0.0035)	(0.0023)
Attendance	0.0173***	0.0163***	−0.0003	0.0504***	−0.0105*
	(0.0036)	(0.0028)	(0.0037)	(0.0045)	(0.0044)
Ideology	−0.0091†	−0.0129**	−0.0109**	0.0098*	−0.0165***
	(0.0052)	(0.0046)	(0.0039)	(0.0048)	(0.0044)
Party identification	0.0169***	−0.0133***	0.0129***	0.0150***	−0.0070*
	(0.0033)	(0.0035)	(0.0032)	(0.0042)	(0.0030)
Education	0.0257***	−0.0021	0.0473***	0.0063	0.0673***
	(0.0054)	(0.0048)	(0.0092)	(0.0054)	(0.0052)
Age	0.0003	−0.0021***	−0.0005	0.0009	0.0008†
	(0.0004)	(0.0004)	(0.0004)	(0.0006)	(0.0004)
Female	−0.0105	0.0346*	−0.0188	−0.0112	−0.0585***
	(0.0167)	(0.0154)	(0.0129)	(0.0147)	(0.0143)
Log family income	−0.0057	−0.0203***	0.0037	−0.0102	0.0290***
	(0.0073)	(0.0053)	(0.0085)	(0.0074)	(0.0035)
Black	0.0078	−0.0088	−0.0395*	0.0465*	−0.1545***
	(0.0179)	(0.0176)	(0.0191)	(0.0198)	(0.0177)
Other race	0.0348	0.0867*	0.0923**	−0.0298	−0.0332
	(0.0849)	(0.0360)	(0.0284)	(0.0670)	(0.0561)
Hispanic	0.1449†	0.1660***	0.0730	0.0252	0.0572
	(0.0822)	(0.0253)	(0.0686)	(0.0552)	(0.0534)
Parental education (years)	0.0039†	−0.0044**	0.0078**	−0.0001	0.0110***
	(0.0022)	(0.0016)	(0.0027)	(0.0020)	(0.0022)
Family income at 16 (1–5)	0.0195*	0.0167**	0.0080	0.0260**	0.0194**
	(0.0092)	(0.0055)	(0.0110)	(0.0086)	(0.0062)
Father's occupational prestige	−0.0001	0.0012*	−0.0001	−0.0001	0.0010†
	(0.0005)	(0.0005)	(0.0006)	(0.0004)	(0.0005)
Type of place at 16 (1–6)	−0.0009	−0.0063	0.0001	−0.0044	0.0169**
	(0.0036)	(0.0050)	(0.0040)	(0.0034)	(0.0054)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1214	1184	1163	1171	1132

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Two-stage least squares as in panel B, adding parental education, family income at 16, father's occupational prestige, type of place at 16, and division-at-16 fixed effects. Sample and outcomes as in panel A. Standard errors are clustered on the childhood denomination.

Table SI-14: Childhood-DII 2SLS with the full childhood-background battery (full coefficients, panel C), columns (6) to (9)

	Confidence in… (1–3, higher = more confidence)			
	Medicine (6)	Education (7)	Press (8)	Television (9)
DII (instrumented)	0.0093***	0.0043*	0.0032	0.0056*
	(0.0018)	(0.0021)	(0.0026)	(0.0023)
Attendance	0.0064*	0.0113***	−0.0054*	−0.0213***
	(0.0025)	(0.0022)	(0.0025)	(0.0031)
Ideology	−0.0070	−0.0271**	−0.0566***	−0.0246**
	(0.0051)	(0.0079)	(0.0078)	(0.0071)
Party identification	0.0010	−0.0088**	−0.0408***	−0.0130***
	(0.0031)	(0.0028)	(0.0038)	(0.0024)
Education	0.0189*	0.0086*	−0.0049	−0.0270**
	(0.0081)	(0.0040)	(0.0059)	(0.0086)
Age	−0.0018***	0.0010†	0.0007	0.0004
	(0.0005)	(0.0005)	(0.0004)	(0.0004)
Female	−0.0278**	0.0003	−0.0024	−0.0048
	(0.0092)	(0.0153)	(0.0092)	(0.0133)
Log family income	0.0127	−0.0200*	−0.0231**	−0.0326***
	(0.0092)	(0.0080)	(0.0074)	(0.0081)
Black	−0.0363**	0.0691***	−0.0072	0.0895***
	(0.0135)	(0.0132)	(0.0253)	(0.0143)
Other race	−0.0668†	0.0897†	0.0641	0.0731
	(0.0364)	(0.0448)	(0.0963)	(0.0554)
Hispanic	−0.0544	0.1509***	0.1045†	0.0070
	(0.0690)	(0.0369)	(0.0611)	(0.0579)
Parental education (years)	0.0014	0.0003	0.0068**	−0.0012
	(0.0017)	(0.0024)	(0.0022)	(0.0020)
Family income at 16 (1–5)	0.0153*	0.0175*	−0.0016	0.0019
	(0.0059)	(0.0086)	(0.0080)	(0.0054)
Father's occupational prestige	0.0001	−0.0008	0.0002	0.0001
	(0.0004)	(0.0005)	(0.0010)	(0.0008)
Type of place at 16 (1–6)	0.0001	−0.0194***	0.0106*	0.0026
	(0.0037)	(0.0041)	(0.0049)	(0.0051)
Observations	11,872	11,856	11,837	11,839
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1192	1198	1253	1207

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Two-stage least squares as in panel B, adding parental education, family income at 16, father's occupational prestige, type of place at 16, and division-at-16 fixed effects. Sample and outcomes as in panel A. Standard errors are clustered on the childhood denomination.

B.3 DII and Populism

Table SI-15 reports full regression tables of the models in panels B and C of Table 6. The models of panel A appear in Table SI-8.

Table SI-15: The people-vs-politicians battery (full coefficients)

	People decide (1)	Do not care (2)	Main problem (3)	Only the rich (4)	Selling out (5)	Trust-worthy (6)	Trusts experts (7)	Need experts (8)
DII (raw, 0–12)	−0.0087	−0.0108**	0.0009	−0.0105	−0.0163**	0.0109***	0.0061*	0.0066
	(0.0052)	(0.0034)	(0.0054)	(0.0063)	(0.0060)	(0.0028)	(0.0030)	(0.0040)
Attendance	−0.0136	−0.0289*	−0.0350***	−0.0228**	−0.0107	0.0236*	−0.0096	0.0057
	(0.0085)	(0.0122)	(0.0094)	(0.0082)	(0.0126)	(0.0101)	(0.0124)	(0.0120)
Ideology	0.0043	0.0515†	0.0747***	−0.0335*	0.1344***	−0.0255	−0.1153***	−0.1005***
	(0.0122)	(0.0287)	(0.0200)	(0.0144)	(0.0171)	(0.0198)	(0.0256)	(0.0188)
Party identification	0.0171*	0.0197	0.0375**	−0.0122	0.0785***	−0.0340*	−0.1030***	−0.0889***
	(0.0083)	(0.0127)	(0.0124)	(0.0099)	(0.0100)	(0.0132)	(0.0157)	(0.0106)
Education	−0.0802***	−0.1160***	−0.0959***	−0.1110***	−0.1722***	0.0175	0.0958***	0.0197†
	(0.0166)	(0.0161)	(0.0161)	(0.0130)	(0.0143)	(0.0124)	(0.0145)	(0.0114)
Age	−0.0017	−0.0043**	−0.0008	−0.0043*	−0.0027**	0.0070***	−0.0028*	0.0027**
	(0.0016)	(0.0014)	(0.0013)	(0.0016)	(0.0008)	(0.0009)	(0.0014)	(0.0009)
Female	0.0261	−0.0076	0.0371	0.0445†	0.0791**	−0.0377	−0.0964***	0.0073
	(0.0332)	(0.0213)	(0.0356)	(0.0242)	(0.0285)	(0.0323)	(0.0139)	(0.0391)
Family-income group	−0.0595***	−0.0524***	−0.0249	−0.0586***	−0.1062***	−0.0170	0.0711***	0.0286†
	(0.0150)	(0.0108)	(0.0185)	(0.0146)	(0.0200)	(0.0145)	(0.0114)	(0.0150)
Black	0.0766	0.0727	0.1698**	0.1650***	0.3545***	−0.0346	−0.2711***	−0.1058†
	(0.0533)	(0.0521)	(0.0536)	(0.0348)	(0.0682)	(0.0581)	(0.0577)	(0.0579)
Other race	−0.0643†	0.1033*	0.0642	0.0704	0.2054*	0.0061	0.0580	0.1157*
	(0.0334)	(0.0463)	(0.0611)	(0.0691)	(0.0776)	(0.0571)	(0.0644)	(0.0478)
Hispanic	0.3283***	0.1036†	0.1418	0.1541*	0.1343	−0.0864	−0.2087	−0.1023
	(0.0700)	(0.0550)	(0.0866)	(0.0762)	(0.1046)	(0.1310)	(0.1627)	(0.0934)
Observations	4,006	4,010	4,010	4,010	4,010	4,010	2,722	2,724
Denominations (clusters)	52	52	52	52	52	52	48	48
Waves	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2020	2020
DV mean	3.50	3.32	3.28	3.55	2.92	2.40	3.18	3.43
DV SD	1.14	1.11	1.08	1.05	1.18	1.02	1.13	1.04

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, ANES time series. The outcomes are the populism items of panel B of Table 6 (columns 1–6, 2016 and 2020 pooled) and the expert-deference items of panel C (columns 7–8, 2020 only) on their native 5-point scales, higher = more agreement. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, family-income quintile, race, and Hispanic origin, with state and wave fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

C Additional Analysis

C.1 Nativism and Racial Resentment

Table SI-16 applies the specification of the CES cells of Table 4 to the CES immigration items of 2016 and the racial-resentment items of 2022.

Table SI-16: DII, nativism, and racial resentment

Item	DII	(SE)	N	Denoms.
CES 2016 immigration (0/1, item selected)				
Grant legal status to employed immigrants (pro)	+0.0011	(0.0011)	18,088	57
Increase border patrols (anti)	-0.0024*	(0.0010)	18,088	57
Legal status for those brought as children (pro)	+0.0014	(0.0015)	18,088	57
Fine businesses hiring illegal immigrants (anti)	-0.0013	(0.0012)	3,967	55
Admit no refugees from Syria (anti)	-0.0030†	(0.0017)	3,967	55
Increase work visas (pro)	+0.0002	(0.0010)	3,967	55
Identify and deport illegal immigrants (anti)	-0.0013	(0.0019)	18,088	57
Ban Muslims from immigrating (anti)	-0.0012	(0.0014)	3,967	55
CES 2022 racial resentment (1–5, higher = more resentful)				
Minorities should overcome without favors	-0.0022	(0.0040)	13,212	57
Slavery did not create lasting conditions	-0.0102*	(0.0039)	13,211	57

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each row is a separate OLS regression of the item on the raw DII (0–12), CES specification as in Table 4: attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, Hispanic origin, and family income, with state fixed effects and standard errors clustered on denomination. Immigration items are 0/1 for selecting the option. Resentment items are on their native 5-point scale coded so that higher values are more resentful. Half-sample immigration items carry smaller N.

C.2 The Attendance Dose

Tables SI-17 and SI-18 add an interaction between the DII and religious attendance to the models of Tables 4 and 6.

Table SI-17: The attendance dose: DII × attendance across the institution matrix

	GSS confidence		ANES thermometer		ANES 2024 trust		CES rating / trust	
	DII at mean att.	DII × att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII × att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII × att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII × att. (SD)
1. National political branches								
Executive / federal govt	0.0049**	0.0052**	0.0074*	0.0049	0.0104**	0.0063†	0.0105*	0.0016
	(0.0018)	(0.0016), n=20,335	(0.0035)	(0.0032), n=5,826	(0.0039)	(0.0034), n=1,603	(0.0040)	(0.0020), n=13,212
Congress	0.0008	0.0043***	0.0015	0.0024	0.0054	-0.0032	—	—
	(0.0016)	(0.0010), n=20,334	(0.0033)	(0.0025), n=9,862	(0.0058)	(0.0036), n=1,606		
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0167***	0.0065***	0.0076***	0.0053*	0.0093	-0.0007	—	—
	(0.0030)	(0.0014), n=20,074	(0.0015)	(0.0021), n=9,257	(0.0068)	(0.0045), n=1,603		
Political parties	—	—	—	—	0.0118*	0.0039	—	—
					(0.0047)	(0.0039), n=1,602		
2. Local political bodies								
Mayor / city manager	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0059***	0.0009
							(0.0016)	(0.0030), n=14,146
City council	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0043*	-0.0001
							(0.0019)	(0.0035), n=14,265
3. Non-political bodies								
Organized religion	0.0151**	0.0126**	—	—	—	—	—	—
	(0.0051)	(0.0039), n=20,161						
Scientific community	0.0133**	0.0092**	—	—	0.0065	0.0011	—	—
	(0.0039)	(0.0027), n=19,468			(0.0051)	(0.0026), n=1,605		
Medicine	0.0111***	0.0046*	—	—	—	—	—	—
	(0.0018)	(0.0018), n=20,508						
Education	0.0082*	0.0054*	—	—	—	—	—	—
	(0.0031)	(0.0021), n=20,450						
Colleges and universities	—	—	—	—	0.0142**	0.0130*	—	—
					(0.0049)	(0.0056), n=1,763		
Local schools	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0079**	-0.0010
							(0.0028)	(0.0016), n=15,330
Press / traditional media	0.0093***	0.0012	—	—	0.0180***	0.0030	—	—
	(0.0017)	(0.0012), n=20,434			(0.0046)	(0.0027), n=1,605		
Television	0.0082**	0.0013	—	—	—	—	—	—
	(0.0029)	(0.0022), n=20,454						

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. OLS only. Each pair of columns reports, from a single regression per cell, the coefficient on raw DII at mean attendance and the DII × attendance interaction, with attendance standardized on the estimation sample and the outcome standardized; controls, fixed effects, and samples exactly as the corresponding cells of Table 4. The interaction reads as the change in the DII effect (in SD of the outcome per index point) per one-SD increase in church attendance. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-18: The attendance dose in the populist-sentiment items (ANES)

	DII at mean att.	(SE)	DII × att. (SD)	(SE)	N
A. Trust in government (cumulative file; outcomes standardized)					
Trusts government to do what is right	0.0096*	(0.0042)	0.0032	(0.0031)	11,248
Government run for the benefit of all	0.0091***	(0.0020)	0.0033	(0.0020)	15,695
Government does not waste tax money	0.0096***	(0.0018)	0.0023†	(0.0013)	16,287
Hardly any officials are crooked	0.0112***	(0.0025)	0.0033	(0.0024)	11,509
B. The people-vs-politicians battery (2016 + 2020; outcomes standardized)					
People, not politicians, should decide policy	-0.0078†	(0.0045)	-0.0010	(0.0031)	4,006
Most politicians do not care about the people	-0.0096**	(0.0032)	0.0010	(0.0037)	4,010
Politicians are the main problem in the U.S.	0.0011	(0.0050)	0.0031	(0.0037)	4,010
Politicians care only about the rich and powerful	-0.0099	(0.0060)	0.0010	(0.0036)	4,010
Compromise in politics is selling out	-0.0145**	(0.0054)	-0.0067	(0.0047)	4,010
Most politicians are trustworthy	0.0107***	(0.0028)	-0.0001	(0.0031)	4,010

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. OLS only; specifications as Table 6 with outcomes standardized, attendance standardized on each estimation sample, and the DII × attendance interaction added. The first coefficient is the DII effect at mean attendance; the interaction is the change in that effect per one-SD increase in attendance. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

C.3 Controlling for Individual-Level Theology

Tables SI-19 and SI-20 add born-again identity and biblical literalism, separately and together, to the models of Tables 4 and 6.

Table SI-19: DII and confidence in institutions, controlling for individual theology

	Baseline	+ Born-again	+ Literalism	+ Both
A. GSS confidence, 1973–2022				
Executive / federal government	0.0046*	0.0073*	0.0053†	0.0048
	(0.0017)	(0.0030)	(0.0027)	(0.0042)
Congress	0.0005	0.0057†	0.0038	0.0052
	(0.0015)	(0.0030)	(0.0027)	(0.0031)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0163***	0.0158***	0.0212***	0.0180**
	(0.0031)	(0.0045)	(0.0036)	(0.0055)
Organized religion	0.0143**	0.0155***	0.0166**	0.0163***
	(0.0049)	(0.0032)	(0.0049)	(0.0040)
Scientific community	0.0126**	0.0146**	0.0123**	0.0133*
	(0.0041)	(0.0052)	(0.0041)	(0.0054)
Medicine	0.0108***	0.0177***	0.0174***	0.0161**
	(0.0017)	(0.0032)	(0.0031)	(0.0047)
Press / traditional media	0.0093***	0.0096***	0.0095***	0.0050*
	(0.0016)	(0.0026)	(0.0014)	(0.0024)
Television	0.0081**	0.0104**	0.0110**	0.0108**
	(0.0028)	(0.0033)	(0.0033)	(0.0032)
Education	0.0079**	0.0102***	0.0109***	0.0097***
	(0.0029)	(0.0018)	(0.0025)	(0.0023)
N	19,468–20,508	7,181–7,412	9,434–9,825	5,819–6,026
B. ANES thermometers, 1980–2024				
Executive / federal government	0.0073*	0.0060†	0.0094**	0.0075*
	(0.0035)	(0.0036)	(0.0033)	(0.0035)
Congress	0.0014	0.0015	0.0038	0.0031
	(0.0033)	(0.0033)	(0.0027)	(0.0029)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0074***	0.0063***	0.0082***	0.0068***
	(0.0015)	(0.0016)	(0.0015)	(0.0016)
N	5,826–9,862	5,307–9,108	5,698–9,636	5,191–8,909
C. ANES 2024 trust				
Executive / federal government	0.0100*	0.0084†	0.0096*	0.0082†
	(0.0039)	(0.0044)	(0.0040)	(0.0043)
Congress	0.0056	0.0055	0.0068	0.0066
	(0.0056)	(0.0052)	(0.0055)	(0.0052)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0094	0.0076	0.0092	0.0080
	(0.0067)	(0.0052)	(0.0062)	(0.0049)
Political parties	0.0115*	0.0081	0.0121*	0.0087
	(0.0047)	(0.0054)	(0.0050)	(0.0055)
Scientific community	0.0065	0.0051	0.0040	0.0035
	(0.0051)	(0.0048)	(0.0048)	(0.0046)
Press / traditional media	0.0178***	0.0156**	0.0170***	0.0154***
	(0.0046)	(0.0045)	(0.0042)	(0.0041)
Colleges and universities	0.0134**	0.0144***	0.0128*	0.0141***
	(0.0048)	(0.0036)	(0.0050)	(0.0038)
N	1,602–1,763	1,582–1,741	1,552–1,707	1,533–1,686
D. CES local rating (2016) and federal trust (2022)				
Executive / federal government	0.0118**	0.0116**		
	(0.0037)	(0.0035)		
Mayor / city manager	0.0059***	0.0059***		
	(0.0016)	(0.0017)		
City council	0.0043*	0.0051*		
	(0.0019)	(0.0022)		
Local schools	0.0079**	0.0080*		
	(0.0028)	(0.0030)		
N	13,212–15,330	13,210–15,323		

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 4, adding the theology items named in the column. The baseline column reproduces that table, and each other column is estimated on the respondents who answered the added items. Coefficients are divided by the standard deviation of the outcome in the baseline sample. Biblical literalism is not asked in the CES. In the ANES cumulative file, literalism before 1990 is the item that the Bible is God's word and all it says is true, and born-again in 1980 and 1984 refers to a born-again experience rather than identity. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

Table SI-20: DII and populist sentiment, controlling for individual theology

	Baseline	+ Born-again	+ Literalism	+ Both
A. Officials and elite capture (ANES cumulative file)				
Hardly any officials crooked (1–3)	0.0072***	0.0068***	0.0076***	0.0072***
	(0.0016)	(0.0018)	(0.0015)	(0.0019)
Run for the benefit of all (0/1)	0.0039***	0.0034***	0.0041***	0.0037***
	(0.0008)	(0.0007)	(0.0009)	(0.0007)
Trust government to do right (1–4)	0.0053*	0.0019	0.0057*	0.0025
	(0.0023)	(0.0026)	(0.0024)	(0.0028)
Does not waste tax money (1–3)	0.0047***	0.0036**	0.0049***	0.0041***
	(0.0008)	(0.0011)	(0.0011)	(0.0011)
N	11,248–16,287	5,739–10,910	7,319–12,222	5,611–10,678
B. People versus politicians (ANES 2016 and 2020, 1–5)				
People, not politicians, should decide	−0.0087	−0.0070	−0.0064	−0.0049
	(0.0052)	(0.0054)	(0.0056)	(0.0058)
Politicians do not care about people	−0.0108**	−0.0092**	−0.0085*	−0.0080*
	(0.0034)	(0.0032)	(0.0035)	(0.0033)
Politicians are the main problem	0.0009	−0.0005	0.0020	0.0000
	(0.0054)	(0.0055)	(0.0053)	(0.0054)
Politicians care only about the rich	−0.0105	−0.0081	−0.0091	−0.0073
	(0.0063)	(0.0063)	(0.0064)	(0.0063)
Compromise is selling out	−0.0163**	−0.0134*	−0.0125*	−0.0122*
	(0.0060)	(0.0058)	(0.0051)	(0.0051)
Most politicians are trustworthy	0.0109***	0.0094**	0.0122***	0.0101**
	(0.0028)	(0.0029)	(0.0030)	(0.0029)
N	4,006–4,010	3,942–3,946	3,878–3,882	3,831–3,835
C. Experts versus the people (ANES 2020, 1–5)				
Trust experts over ordinary people	0.0061*	0.0075†	0.0064*	0.0081*
	(0.0030)	(0.0044)	(0.0025)	(0.0037)
Ordinary people need experts' help	0.0066	0.0069†	0.0065	0.0074
	(0.0040)	(0.0040)	(0.0051)	(0.0050)
N	2,722–2,724	2,663–2,665	2,606–2,608	2,562–2,564

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 6, adding the theology items named in the column. The baseline column reproduces that table, and each other column is estimated on the respondents who answered the added items. Outcomes are on their native scales. Biblical literalism is not asked in the CES. In the ANES cumulative file, literalism before 1990 is the item that the Bible is God's word and all it says is true, and born-again in 1980 and 1984 refers to a born-again experience rather than identity. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

C.4 Subgroups by Theology and Politics

Tables SI-21 to SI-24 re-estimate the models of Tables 4 and 6 within subgroups defined by born-again identity, biblical literalism, ideology, and party identification.

Table SI-21: DII and confidence in institutions, by born-again identity and biblical literalism

		Born-again		Biblical literalist	
	All	Yes	No	Yes	No
A. GSS confidence, 1973–2022					
Executive / federal government	0.0046*	0.0060	0.0074†	0.0066*	0.0022
	(0.0017)	(0.0041)	(0.0038)	(0.0031)	(0.0029)
Congress	0.0005	0.0064	0.0047	0.0102**	−0.0011
	(0.0015)	(0.0039)	(0.0039)	(0.0034)	(0.0039)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0163***	0.0119*	0.0170**	0.0215***	0.0175***
	(0.0031)	(0.0055)	(0.0054)	(0.0054)	(0.0030)
Organized religion	0.0143**	0.0147***	0.0150***	0.0193**	0.0129*
	(0.0049)	(0.0036)	(0.0035)	(0.0057)	(0.0063)
Scientific community	0.0126**	0.0190***	0.0058	0.0135**	0.0096†
	(0.0041)	(0.0050)	(0.0070)	(0.0043)	(0.0048)
Medicine	0.0108***	0.0185***	0.0156***	0.0213***	0.0135**
	(0.0017)	(0.0042)	(0.0042)	(0.0036)	(0.0041)
Press / traditional media	0.0093***	0.0098*	0.0068	0.0081*	0.0083***
	(0.0016)	(0.0037)	(0.0052)	(0.0038)	(0.0021)
Television	0.0081**	0.0100†	0.0082*	0.0151**	0.0059†
	(0.0028)	(0.0051)	(0.0032)	(0.0050)	(0.0032)
Education	0.0079**	0.0074*	0.0120***	0.0105**	0.0081**
	(0.0029)	(0.0033)	(0.0023)	(0.0036)	(0.0024)
N	19,468–20,508	4,154–4,289	3,027–3,123	4,076–4,312	5,358–5,513
B. ANES thermometers, 1980–2024					
Executive / federal government	0.0073*	0.0115**	−0.0035	0.0148*	0.0034
	(0.0035)	(0.0037)	(0.0049)	(0.0063)	(0.0049)
Congress	0.0014	0.0002	0.0007	0.0045	0.0022
	(0.0033)	(0.0033)	(0.0042)	(0.0027)	(0.0040)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0074***	0.0089***	−0.0018	0.0094**	0.0035
	(0.0015)	(0.0021)	(0.0030)	(0.0035)	(0.0039)
N	5,826–9,862	2,924–4,993	2,383–4,115	2,667–4,203	3,031–5,433
C. ANES 2024 trust					
Executive / federal government	0.0100*	0.0068	0.0028	0.0174†	0.0064
	(0.0039)	(0.0067)	(0.0063)	(0.0091)	(0.0055)
Congress	0.0056	0.0077	−0.0042	0.0189†	0.0043
	(0.0056)	(0.0073)	(0.0058)	(0.0095)	(0.0066)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0094	−0.0015	0.0120	0.0163†	0.0054
	(0.0067)	(0.0114)	(0.0080)	(0.0091)	(0.0081)
Political parties	0.0115*	0.0078	0.0001	0.0171†	0.0097
	(0.0047)	(0.0059)	(0.0084)	(0.0095)	(0.0059)
Scientific community	0.0065	−0.0051	0.0057	0.0036	0.0021
	(0.0051)	(0.0071)	(0.0085)	(0.0087)	(0.0058)
Press / traditional media	0.0178***	0.0091	0.0156*	0.0196**	0.0131*
	(0.0046)	(0.0072)	(0.0066)	(0.0071)	(0.0060)
Colleges and universities	0.0134**	0.0193*	0.0071	0.0092	0.0118*
	(0.0048)	(0.0080)	(0.0084)	(0.0135)	(0.0051)
N	1,602–1,763	882–977	700–764	595–663	956–1,044
D. CES local rating (2016) and federal trust (2022)					
Executive / federal government	0.0118**	0.0127*	0.0055*		
	(0.0037)	(0.0054)	(0.0025)		
Mayor / city manager	0.0059***	0.0070***	0.0047		
	(0.0016)	(0.0020)	(0.0033)		
City council	0.0043*	0.0056*	0.0042		
	(0.0019)	(0.0023)	(0.0047)		
Local schools	0.0079**	0.0069*	0.0090†		
	(0.0028)	(0.0027)	(0.0050)		
N	13,212–15,330	7,722–8,548	5,488–6,775		

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression estimated within the column's subgroup, with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 4. The first column reproduces that table. Coefficients are divided by the standard deviation of the outcome in the full sample. Biblical literalism is not asked in the CES. In the ANES cumulative file, literalism before 1990 is the item that the Bible is God's word and all it says is true, and born-again in 1980 and 1984 refers to a born-again experience rather than identity. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

Table SI-22: DII and populist sentiment, by born-again identity and biblical literalism

		Born-again		Biblical literalist	
	All	Yes	No	Yes	No
A. Officials and elite capture (ANES cumulative file)					
Hardly any officials crooked (1–3)	0.0072***	0.0063***	0.0045*	0.0091***	0.0052**
	(0.0016)	(0.0016)	(0.0018)	(0.0019)	(0.0017)
Run for the benefit of all (0/1)	0.0039***	0.0037**	0.0014	0.0024**	0.0045***
	(0.0008)	(0.0012)	(0.0012)	(0.0009)	(0.0012)
Trust government to do right (1–4)	0.0053*	0.0005	0.0015	0.0081**	0.0025
	(0.0023)	(0.0039)	(0.0018)	(0.0030)	(0.0024)
Does not waste tax money (1–3)	0.0047***	0.0029†	0.0020	0.0037†	0.0045***
	(0.0008)	(0.0016)	(0.0016)	(0.0020)	(0.0009)
N	11,248–16,287	2,954–5,902	2,785–5,008	3,522–5,493	3,797–6,729
B. People versus politicians (ANES 2016 and 2020, 1–5)					
People, not politicians, should decide	−0.0087	−0.0088	−0.0072	0.0052	−0.0088
	(0.0052)	(0.0068)	(0.0052)	(0.0060)	(0.0064)
Politicians do not care about people	−0.0108**	−0.0067	−0.0103†	−0.0062	−0.0075†
	(0.0034)	(0.0062)	(0.0059)	(0.0054)	(0.0039)
Politicians are the main problem	0.0009	−0.0006	−0.0006	0.0049	0.0012
	(0.0054)	(0.0063)	(0.0101)	(0.0068)	(0.0065)
Politicians care only about the rich	−0.0105	−0.0051	−0.0101	−0.0061	−0.0096
	(0.0063)	(0.0063)	(0.0070)	(0.0057)	(0.0068)
Compromise is selling out	−0.0163**	−0.0120	−0.0127*	−0.0116†	−0.0107*
	(0.0060)	(0.0092)	(0.0057)	(0.0068)	(0.0049)
Most politicians are trustworthy	0.0109***	0.0090*	0.0074†	0.0002	0.0153***
	(0.0028)	(0.0034)	(0.0042)	(0.0055)	(0.0023)
N	4,006–4,010	2,177–2,179	1,765–1,769	1,492–1,494	2,386–2,389
C. Experts versus the people (ANES 2020, 1–5)					
Trust experts over ordinary people	0.0061*	0.0075	0.0080	−0.0075	0.0106***
	(0.0030)	(0.0095)	(0.0059)	(0.0060)	(0.0024)
Ordinary people need experts' help	0.0066	0.0165***	−0.0003	0.0090	0.0058
	(0.0040)	(0.0043)	(0.0068)	(0.0069)	(0.0068)
N	2,722–2,724	1,463–1,465	1,200	983–986	1,622–1,623

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression estimated within the column's subgroup, with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 6. The first column reproduces that table. Outcomes are on their native scales. Biblical literalism is not asked in the CES. In the ANES cumulative file, literalism before 1990 is the item that the Bible is God's word and all it says is true, and born-again in 1980 and 1984 refers to a born-again experience rather than identity. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

Table SI-23: DII and confidence in institutions, by ideology and party

		Ideology			Party		
	All	Conservative	Moderate	Liberal	Republican	Independent	Democrat
A. GSS confidence, 1973–2022							
Executive / federal government	0.0046*	0.0064**	0.0021	0.0039	0.0045	0.0090†	−0.0002
	(0.0017)	(0.0023)	(0.0018)	(0.0030)	(0.0028)	(0.0050)	(0.0020)
Congress	0.0005	0.0006	−0.0013	0.0035	0.0016	0.0015	−0.0019
	(0.0015)	(0.0024)	(0.0018)	(0.0032)	(0.0015)	(0.0067)	(0.0020)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0163***	0.0202***	0.0088*	0.0190***	0.0177***	0.0137*	0.0144***
	(0.0031)	(0.0030)	(0.0038)	(0.0053)	(0.0043)	(0.0052)	(0.0026)
Organized religion	0.0143**	0.0165***	0.0130*	0.0129	0.0184***	0.0086	0.0114†
	(0.0049)	(0.0040)	(0.0054)	(0.0085)	(0.0041)	(0.0083)	(0.0061)
Scientific community	0.0126**	0.0144***	0.0090†	0.0118	0.0150**	0.0135**	0.0067
	(0.0041)	(0.0028)	(0.0047)	(0.0070)	(0.0047)	(0.0044)	(0.0047)
Medicine	0.0108***	0.0140***	0.0080**	0.0088*	0.0106***	0.0112**	0.0081**
	(0.0017)	(0.0025)	(0.0023)	(0.0034)	(0.0025)	(0.0035)	(0.0025)
Press / traditional media	0.0093***	0.0111***	0.0051*	0.0098*	0.0052†	0.0169***	0.0088***
	(0.0016)	(0.0022)	(0.0022)	(0.0049)	(0.0027)	(0.0038)	(0.0015)
Television	0.0081**	0.0134***	0.0032	0.0048	0.0060*	0.0086*	0.0075*
	(0.0028)	(0.0036)	(0.0025)	(0.0038)	(0.0025)	(0.0036)	(0.0032)
Education	0.0079**	0.0148***	−0.0002	0.0073†	0.0120***	0.0047	0.0024
	(0.0029)	(0.0035)	(0.0036)	(0.0036)	(0.0031)	(0.0035)	(0.0036)
N	19,468–20,508	7,553–7,891	7,392–7,880	4,523–4,737	7,952–8,308	2,210–2,357	9,306–9,845
B. ANES thermometers, 1980–2024							
Executive / federal government	0.0073*	0.0082	0.0011	0.0085	0.0083	−0.0011	0.0045
	(0.0035)	(0.0059)	(0.0040)	(0.0058)	(0.0067)	(0.0071)	(0.0043)
Congress	0.0014	0.0049	−0.0021	−0.0006	0.0026	0.0006	−0.0009
	(0.0033)	(0.0043)	(0.0035)	(0.0044)	(0.0052)	(0.0101)	(0.0019)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0074***	0.0125***	−0.0025	0.0031	0.0088**	0.0112	0.0013
	(0.0015)	(0.0018)	(0.0044)	(0.0056)	(0.0026)	(0.0076)	(0.0029)
N	5,826–9,862	2,748–4,786	1,803–2,811	1,275–2,265	2,671–4,880	475–733	2,680–4,249
C. ANES 2024 trust							
Executive / federal government	0.0100*	0.0102	0.0027	0.0147	0.0100		0.0117
	(0.0039)	(0.0090)	(0.0136)	(0.0155)	(0.0094)		(0.0107)
Congress	0.0056	0.0088	−0.0070	0.0080	0.0072		0.0045
	(0.0056)	(0.0108)	(0.0126)	(0.0132)	(0.0110)		(0.0097)
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0094	0.0069	0.0050	0.0129	0.0058		0.0149
	(0.0067)	(0.0055)	(0.0109)	(0.0179)	(0.0078)		(0.0148)
Political parties	0.0115*	0.0136	0.0014	0.0162	0.0059		0.0174†
	(0.0047)	(0.0102)	(0.0091)	(0.0112)	(0.0110)		(0.0094)
Scientific community	0.0065	0.0076	0.0056	−0.0067	0.0048		0.0028
	(0.0051)	(0.0092)	(0.0138)	(0.0099)	(0.0071)		(0.0083)
Press / traditional media	0.0178***	0.0179**	0.0165†	0.0163†	0.0178*		0.0145†
	(0.0046)	(0.0063)	(0.0084)	(0.0088)	(0.0072)		(0.0073)
Colleges and universities	0.0134**	0.0150**	0.0039	0.0098	0.0119*		0.0138
	(0.0048)	(0.0050)	(0.0096)	(0.0099)	(0.0054)		(0.0082)
N	1,602–1,763	821–919	394–431	387–413	915–1,019		630–678
D. CES local rating (2016) and federal trust (2022)							
Executive / federal government	0.0118**	0.0105**	0.0169***	−0.0001	0.0078*	0.0031	0.0058
	(0.0037)	(0.0038)	(0.0042)	(0.0052)	(0.0031)	(0.0047)	(0.0036)
Mayor / city manager	0.0059***	0.0048*	0.0090**	−0.0001	0.0002	−0.0025	0.0104**
	(0.0016)	(0.0022)	(0.0027)	(0.0054)	(0.0024)	(0.0062)	(0.0034)
City council	0.0043*	0.0023	0.0075*	0.0004	0.0006	−0.0051	0.0067*
	(0.0019)	(0.0028)	(0.0036)	(0.0049)	(0.0024)	(0.0065)	(0.0031)
Local schools	0.0079**	0.0063*	0.0080*	0.0083	0.0039	0.0027	0.0119**
	(0.0028)	(0.0027)	(0.0033)	(0.0058)	(0.0023)	(0.0063)	(0.0036)
N	13,212–15,330	6,379–7,112	4,127–5,261	2,706–2,957	6,827–7,418	1,309–1,824	5,033–6,088

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression estimated within the column's subgroup, with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 4. The first column reproduces that table. Coefficients are divided by the standard deviation of the outcome in the full sample. Republicans and Democrats include leaners. Independents are pure independents. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

Table SI-24: DII and populist sentiment, by ideology and party

		Ideology			Party		
	All	Conservative	Moderate	Liberal	Republican	Independent	Democrat
A. Officials and elite capture (ANES cumulative file)							
Hardly any officials crooked (1–3)	0.0072***	0.0067**	0.0051**	0.0099**	0.0076**	0.0091	0.0056***
	(0.0016)	(0.0024)	(0.0017)	(0.0032)	(0.0022)	(0.0084)	(0.0014)
Run for the benefit of all (0/1)	0.0039***	0.0032*	0.0029*	0.0048***	0.0035***	0.0004	0.0031**
	(0.0008)	(0.0013)	(0.0011)	(0.0013)	(0.0009)	(0.0024)	(0.0011)
Trust government to do right (1–4)	0.0053*	0.0061†	0.0031	0.0052†	0.0063†	−0.0059†	0.0047*
	(0.0023)	(0.0036)	(0.0021)	(0.0030)	(0.0032)	(0.0029)	(0.0018)
Does not waste tax money (1–3)	0.0047***	0.0029**	0.0026	0.0085***	0.0018†	0.0032	0.0061***
	(0.0008)	(0.0010)	(0.0021)	(0.0020)	(0.0010)	(0.0029)	(0.0010)
N	11,248–16,287	5,100–7,655	3,842–5,078	2,306–3,554	5,147–7,844	1,032–1,385	5,069–7,058
B. People versus politicians (ANES 2016 and 2020, 1–5)							
People, not politicians, should decide	−0.0087	−0.0089	−0.0030	−0.0073	−0.0109	−0.0211†	−0.0010
	(0.0052)	(0.0077)	(0.0085)	(0.0059)	(0.0074)	(0.0122)	(0.0041)
Politicians do not care about people	−0.0108**	−0.0074*	−0.0099	−0.0137	−0.0069	−0.0217†	−0.0115
	(0.0034)	(0.0034)	(0.0073)	(0.0094)	(0.0045)	(0.0112)	(0.0069)
Politicians are the main problem	0.0009	−0.0007	0.0031	−0.0009	0.0044	−0.0255*	−0.0004
	(0.0054)	(0.0057)	(0.0103)	(0.0096)	(0.0066)	(0.0122)	(0.0077)
Politicians care only about the rich	−0.0105	−0.0084	−0.0053	−0.0177*	−0.0093	−0.0154†	−0.0106
	(0.0063)	(0.0091)	(0.0085)	(0.0066)	(0.0089)	(0.0088)	(0.0067)
Compromise is selling out	−0.0163**	−0.0169*	−0.0190***	−0.0102	−0.0155*	−0.0440**	−0.0105
	(0.0060)	(0.0065)	(0.0049)	(0.0115)	(0.0068)	(0.0149)	(0.0076)
Most politicians are trustworthy	0.0109***	0.0077	0.0000	0.0225***	0.0049	−0.0068	0.0198***
	(0.0028)	(0.0050)	(0.0087)	(0.0056)	(0.0048)	(0.0158)	(0.0047)
N	4,006–4,010	2,030–2,032	977–978	999–1,002	2,214–2,216	306–307	1,486–1,489
C. Experts versus the people (ANES 2020, 1–5)							
Trust experts over ordinary people	0.0061*	0.0107*	0.0019	0.0034	0.0082	0.0117	−0.0007
	(0.0030)	(0.0048)	(0.0053)	(0.0062)	(0.0056)	(0.0257)	(0.0074)
Ordinary people need experts' help	0.0066	0.0091	0.0211**	−0.0072	0.0119**	0.0142	−0.0032
	(0.0040)	(0.0061)	(0.0075)	(0.0078)	(0.0041)	(0.0151)	(0.0076)
N	2,722–2,724	1,374–1,376	634–635	713–714	1,503–1,504	197–198	1,022

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from a separate OLS regression estimated within the column's subgroup, with the specification of the corresponding cell in Table 6. The first column reproduces that table. Outcomes are on their native scales. Republicans and Democrats include leaners. Independents are pure independents. Standard errors, clustered on the denomination, in parentheses.

D Robustness Checks

D.1 Restricting to Waves That Ask for the Specific Denomination

Table SI-25 restricts the GSS and ANES samples to the waves that ask for the specific denomination, 1984 and later in the GSS and 1990 and later in the ANES.

Table SI-25: Restricting to the years with detailed denomination codes

	Full sample			Detailed-code years		
Outcome	DII	(SE)	N	DII	(SE)	N
GSS confidence (detailed codes from 1984)						
U.S. Supreme Court	$+0.0109^{***}$	(0.0020)	20,074	$+0.0124^{***}$	(0.0020)	14,137
Executive branch	$+0.0031^{*}$	(0.0012)	20,335	$+0.0029^{\dagger}$	(0.0015)	14,299
Congress	+0.0003	(0.0009)	20,334	+0.0007	(0.0018)	14,302
Organized religion	$+0.0095^{**}$	(0.0033)	20,161	$+0.0096^{**}$	(0.0030)	14,222
Scientific community	$+0.0078^{**}$	(0.0025)	19,468	$+0.0079^{**}$	(0.0028)	13,839
Medicine	$+0.0068^{***}$	(0.0011)	20,508	$+0.0096^{***}$	(0.0014)	14,409
Press	$+0.0062^{***}$	(0.0011)	20,434	$+0.0068^{***}$	(0.0013)	14,363
Television	$+0.0053^{**}$	(0.0018)	20,454	$+0.0062^{**}$	(0.0019)	14,380
Education	$+0.0051^{**}$	(0.0019)	20,450	$+0.0059^{**}$	(0.0018)	14,380
ANES cumulative (detailed codes from 1990)						
Thermometer: Supreme Court	$+0.1468^{***}$	(0.0294)	9,257	$+0.1623^{***}$	(0.0426)	7,440
Thermometer: federal government	$+0.1647^{*}$	(0.0794)	5,826	$+0.1576^{\dagger}$	(0.0891)	4,673
Thermometer: Congress	+0.0305	(0.0716)	9,862	+0.0295	(0.0766)	8,714
Trusts government to do right	$+0.0053^{*}$	(0.0023)	11,248	$+0.0063^{**}$	(0.0020)	5,204
Government run for benefit of all	$+0.0039^{***}$	(0.0008)	15,695	$+0.0035^{***}$	(0.0008)	10,431
Government does not waste taxes	$+0.0047^{***}$	(0.0008)	16,287	$+0.0043^{**}$	(0.0012)	10,642
Hardly any officials crooked	$+0.0072^{***}$	(0.0016)	11,509	$+0.0080^{***}$	(0.0018)	6,435

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each row compares the specification of Table 4 on the full sample with the same model restricted to the years in which the survey probes specific denominational bodies: 1984 and later in the GSS, 1990 and later in the ANES. Before those years most Protestants carry only a family-level code and score by the family fallback. The restriction changes the survey instrument, not the respondents, so it bounds the contribution of the family fill without selecting on who names a body. Outcomes on their native scales. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

D.2 Dropping the Nondenominational Cell

Table SI-26 re-estimates the models of Tables 4 and 6 after dropping every nondenominational entity, so that the gradient is identified among respondents who belong to a named body.

Table SI-26: Dropping the nondenominational cell

	Full sample			Nondenominational dropped		
Outcome	DII	(SE)	N	DII	(SE)	N
GSS confidence						
U.S. Supreme Court	+0.0109***	(0.0020)	20,074	+0.0135***	(0.0017)	17,780
Executive branch	+0.0031*	(0.0012)	20,335	+0.0042**	(0.0012)	18,020
Congress	+0.0003	(0.0009)	20,334	-0.0005	(0.0010)	18,029
Organized religion	+0.0095**	(0.0033)	20,161	+0.0060*	(0.0029)	17,881
Scientific community	+0.0078**	(0.0025)	19,468	+0.0109***	(0.0019)	17,225
Medicine	+0.0068***	(0.0011)	20,508	+0.0064***	(0.0015)	18,186
Press	+0.0062***	(0.0011)	20,434	+0.0056**	(0.0020)	18,117
Television	+0.0053**	(0.0018)	20,454	+0.0031†	(0.0017)	18,143
Education	+0.0051**	(0.0019)	20,450	+0.0026*	(0.0011)	18,126
ANES cumulative						
Thermometer: Supreme Court	+0.1468***	(0.0294)	9,257	+0.1342**	(0.0453)	7,841
Thermometer: federal government	+0.1647*	(0.0794)	5,826	+0.0962	(0.1057)	5,066
Thermometer: Congress	+0.0305	(0.0716)	9,862	-0.0914†	(0.0505)	8,369
Trusts government to do right	+0.0053*	(0.0023)	11,248	+0.0026*	(0.0011)	10,181
Government run for benefit of all	+0.0039***	(0.0008)	15,695	+0.0031**	(0.0010)	13,675
Government does not waste taxes	+0.0047***	(0.0008)	16,287	+0.0050**	(0.0015)	14,203
Hardly any officials crooked	+0.0072***	(0.0016)	11,509	+0.0066**	(0.0024)	10,303
ANES waves						
ANES 2024: scientists	+0.0051	(0.0041)	1,605	+0.0056	(0.0045)	1,546
ANES 2024: judiciary	+0.0067	(0.0048)	1,603	+0.0060	(0.0050)	1,544
ANES 2024: Congress	+0.0040	(0.0040)	1,606	+0.0030	(0.0038)	1,547
ANES 2024: government	+0.0074*	(0.0029)	1,603	+0.0083**	(0.0030)	1,544
ANES 2024: political parties	+0.0082*	(0.0034)	1,602	+0.0082*	(0.0034)	1,543
ANES 2024: traditional media	+0.0156***	(0.0041)	1,605	+0.0139***	(0.0037)	1,546
Colleges and universities (2024)	+0.0227**	(0.0081)	1,763	+0.0192**	(0.0064)	1,700
ANES populism						
People, not politicians, decide	-0.0087	(0.0052)	4,006	-0.0093	(0.0059)	3,337
Politicians do not care	-0.0108**	(0.0034)	4,010	-0.0128**	(0.0038)	3,341
Politicians the main problem	+0.0009	(0.0054)	4,010	-0.0002	(0.0065)	3,340
Politicians care only about rich	-0.0105	(0.0063)	4,010	-0.0150*	(0.0067)	3,340
Compromise is selling out	-0.0163**	(0.0060)	4,010	-0.0222**	(0.0078)	3,340
Most politicians trustworthy	+0.0109***	(0.0028)	4,010	+0.0100**	(0.0032)	3,341
Trusts experts over ordinary people	+0.0061*	(0.0030)	2,722	+0.0060	(0.0043)	2,306
Ordinary people need experts	+0.0066	(0.0040)	2,724	+0.0058	(0.0046)	2,307
CES 2016 local (standardized)						
Local schools	+0.0079**	(0.0028)	15,330	+0.0056†	(0.0029)	13,339
Mayor / city manager	+0.0059***	(0.0016)	14,146	+0.0044*	(0.0019)	12,291
City council	+0.0043*	(0.0019)	14,265	+0.0026	(0.0017)	12,398

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each row compares the specification of Tables 4 and 6 on the full sample with the same model after dropping every nondenominational entity. GSS and ANES outcomes on their native scales, CES outcomes standardized as in Table 4. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

E Catholic Exceptionalism?

Although the main body of the paper focuses on American Protestants, I am also interested in how similar Catholics are to Protestants, and in what respects they differ, especially from Protestants in more institutionalized churches. In particular, I focus on two questions. Do Catholics have higher or lower trust in secular institutions than members of more institutionalized Protestant denominations? And are the differences narrowing among the younger cohorts, as the historical memory of discrimination fades?

To examine these questions, I use the GSS cumulative file, the source with the most comprehensive coverage of institutions and the longest time series, and focus on Catholics and on Protestants whose denominations score 9 or above on the DII. I first regress confidence in each of the nine institutions the GSS covers on a Catholic indicator, with the controls and fixed effects of Table 4. The coefficient can be interpreted as the trust gap between Catholics and Protestants whose churches organize authority in a way most similar to the Catholic Church.

Table SI-27: Catholics against Protestants in highly institutionalized bodies, GSS confidence items

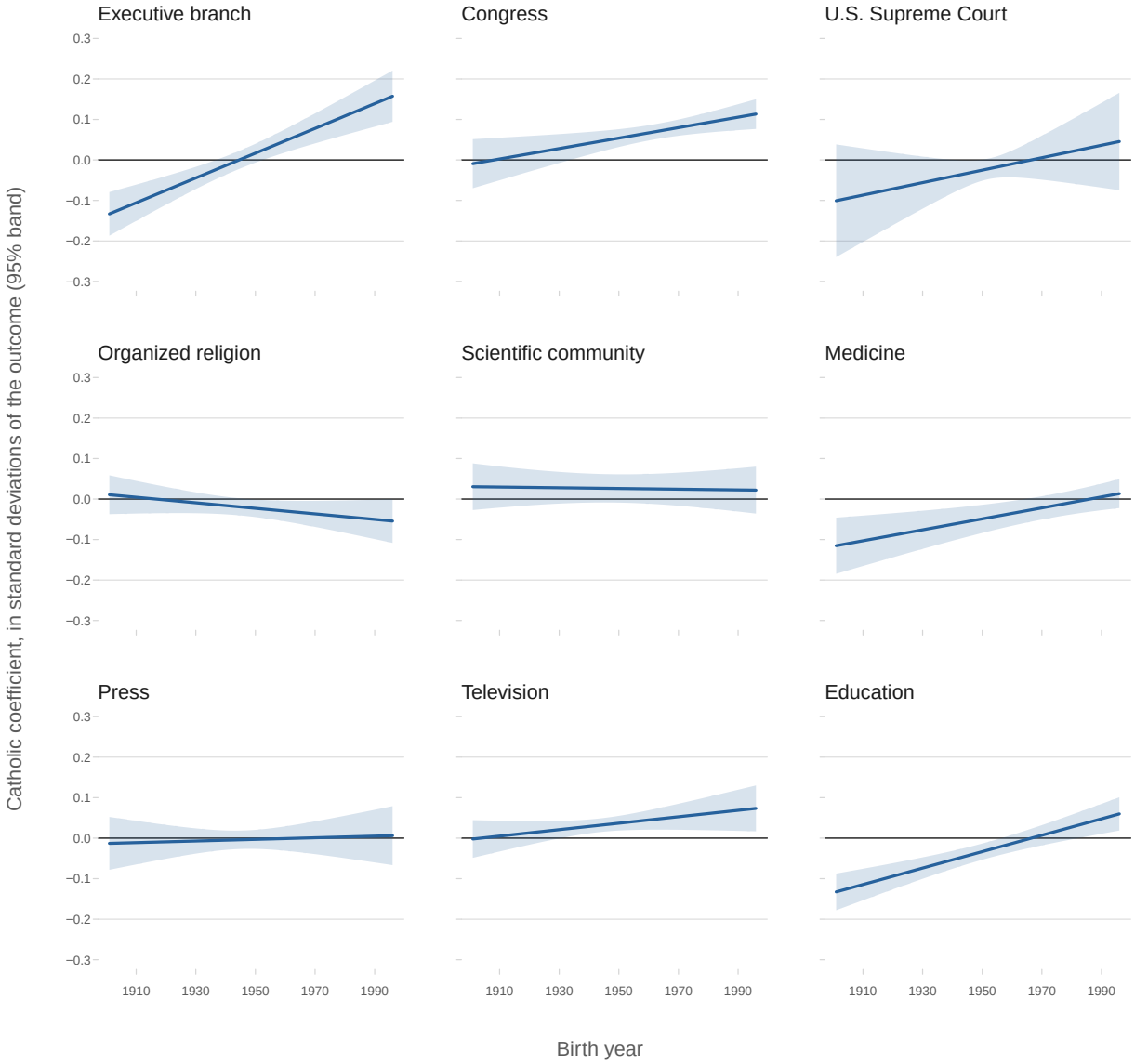
Dependent variable	Coef.	(SE)	N	Catholics
Executive branch	0.0053	(0.0142)	17,582	9,247
Congress	0.0492***	(0.0126)	17,596	9,247
U.S. Supreme Court	-0.0308†	(0.0151)	17,426	9,184
Organized religion	-0.0204†	(0.0112)	17,497	9,226
Scientific community	0.0264	(0.0179)	17,010	9,001
Medicine	-0.0541*	(0.0190)	17,746	9,343
Press	-0.0039	(0.0115)	17,671	9,295
Television	0.0339**	(0.0093)	17,713	9,328
Education	-0.0409**	(0.0135)	17,702	9,328

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. GSS 1974 to 2022, Catholics and Protestants in denominations scoring 9 or higher on the index. Each row reports the coefficient on a Catholic indicator, with the outcome standardized. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log family income, as well as race and ethnicity, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on the denomination, with Catholics as one cluster.

Table SI-27 shows that Catholics report less confidence than high-index Protestants in the Supreme Court, organized religion, medicine, and education, and more confidence in Congress and television. The pattern is consistent with the historical experience of Catholics building parallel institutions of their own, especially schools and hospitals.

Figure SI-1, which interacts the Catholic indicator with birth year, shows the difference across cohorts. For the executive branch, Congress, medicine, and education, the Catholic coefficient rises with birth year, with older Catholics trusting these institutions less than their Protestant counterparts and younger Catholics trusting them as much or more. The Supreme Court and television move in the same direction, though the trends are imprecise. Overall, the pattern indicates that the trust gap between Catholics and Protestants existed among older generations and has been closing among younger ones, whose experiences with these institutions are more similar to those of Protestants. The one exception is organized

Figure SI-1: Catholics against high-index Protestants, by birth year



Notes. Each panel plots the coefficient on the Catholic indicator at each birth year from 1901 to 1996, with the Catholic indicator interacted with birth year. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log family income, as well as race and ethnicity, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. Shaded areas are 95% confidence bands from standard errors clustered on the denomination.

religion, where the gap widens among younger cohorts, a pattern that could reflect greater exposure to the clerical abuse scandals in recent decades.